

Socratic and Confucian Tutors at Home

Where do children's learning beliefs come from? Do they come from their inborn capacity, or from their social and cultural environment? This seemingly prosaic question is actually far from being so as it lies at the heart of the persistent debate about nature and nurture. This very question is also at the center of the never-ending debate on parenting styles and child outcomes. We know that children are born with capacity to learn.¹ But we also know that no child is born with set learning beliefs (or any beliefs, for that matter). Their learning beliefs develop as they grow older. Because children acquire different learning beliefs that reflect their cultural learning models,² I focus on the sociocultural contribution to their developing learning beliefs. In this chapter, I hope to show that European-American homes are full of Socratic tutors whereas Chinese homes host plenty of Confucian tutors. These tutors are the *parents* who use culturally informed strategies to foster learning beliefs in their children.

MOST WILLING AND EFFECTIVE EXECUTORS OF CULTURAL PRESCRIPTIONS

It is a truism that home is where children are nourished and loved, which is undoubtedly the foundation for human survival and well-being. But home, as anthropologists have long discovered, also does for humans something extraordinary, yet largely unnoticeable: It serves as the most fertile ground for the transmission, maintenance, and renewal of culture, any culture.³ Richard Shweder, a leader in cultural psychology, wrote recently that the task of cultural psychologists is to describe and understand cultural prescriptions and how such prescriptions are carried out in child development.⁴ By "prescriptions" Shweder meant the values and preferences held by culture that inform childrearing practices.

As it turns out, the most willing and effective executors of cultural prescriptions are parents and other caregivers in the home. They are tireless in their effort to bring up children, purposefully but more often unintentionally, according to the values they hold dear. People acquire values via the process of experiencing, appropriating, internalizing, or even reconfiguring various events and norms of their daily lives. However, regardless of how they enter individual people's minds, these values are inevitably those of their own culture (or more than one culture if a given child is raised in varying cultural settings, such as immigrant children). Although individual parents have their idiosyncrasies in their childrearing practices, they also share related cultural values with other parents. Consequently, what appears to be a mundane routine of parents' work is not mundane at all, but a testimonial to the immense power of culture. That power lies in the very fact that individual parents' diligence in raising their children is repeated many a time and all the time, resulting in the certain achievement of enduring cultural values. Yet, astonishingly, despite being the most willing and effective executors of cultural prescriptions, parents often are not even aware of the essential role they play. There is little wonder why developmental researchers turn their attention to their work in the home. Home is a gold mine for understanding the nurture part of the nature-nurture equation.

The work parents do to raise their children is generally understood as the process of *socialization* in child development. Socialization refers to the process by which the social world tries to guide, encourage, instill, instruct, model, correct, and discipline children toward the acquisition of desired beliefs and behaviors according to cultural values and norms. Clearly, socialization is not limited to parents, but parents do most of the work, particularly in the formative years of children's lives.⁵ To describe how children develop their learning beliefs, we must look not only at what children know at what age independent of their social world, but what parents do and how they do it to socialize their children.

In this chapter, I present research findings – mostly my own research with Heidi Fung from Academia Sinica, Taiwan, as my collaborator – on how European-American and Taiwanese parents socialize their children in developing their learning beliefs. We focus on the daily communications between parents and children. The research findings seem to encourage the view that parents from both cultures are not only highly motivated in their parenting effort, but also are skilled tutors of their children. Despite some common socialization processes, there are indeed large cultural differences in the kind of habit of thought they forge, as well as the kind of affect they promote. In particular, European-American parents resemble

the age-honored Socratic tutoring style in the West. Likewise, Taiwanese parents tutor their children similar to the Confucian style. Each serves to reproduce generations of learners desired by their culture.

CAPTURE THE FLOW OF SOCIALIZATION

In spite of the recognized importance, research on socialization of children's learning beliefs is surprisingly limited, although socialization of other areas such as cognition, the self, gender roles, and emotion has been well studied. Scarce research on the socialization of learning beliefs owes in part to the fact that learning beliefs have only been studied recently (although achievement motivation has been studied extensively). Another impediment, as far as I see, lies in the inherent difficulty of conducting research on the process of socialization. Socialization is not a static state but a process, and is ongoing. It is notoriously hard, if not altogether impossible, to try to capture something that is by nature changing constantly, like the flowing water in a river. The empirical difficulties become even more pronounced when researchers attempt to consider different cultural patterns. Even if capturing the enigmatic nature of flowing socialization could be done, researchers would still face the perennial problem of limited resources and time. Such limitations prevent them from the ideal research of immersing themselves in the cultural settings to observe naturally occurring events.

Thanks to advancements in empirical methodology, there are ways to conduct such research within the confines of limited resources without compromising the validity of the flowing socializing process. I find particularly useful the empirical method of collecting a simulated conversation between a parent and his or her child about a given topic. Parent-child talk is a core component of the flow of their daily interactions. Much socialization is achieved via such communication at home. Although socialization is ongoing, researchers can still take a specimen for a manageable duration to examine. Or to continue the river metaphor, we can scoop the flowing water for a short time and then analyze what is inside the water. In such samples of daily communication, we are likely to see a spectrum of culturally encoded concepts, beliefs, and affects that are expressed, exchanged, and responded to. What is valued or not valued, approved or disapproved, and accepted or rejected are displayed. We are also likely to see negotiations, disagreements, and resolutions between parents and children. Of course, the specimen is not the full picture, but it nevertheless represents a reasonable degree of real parent-child interaction because the specimen is collected in real time in which the parent is trying to socialize the child. This method has been used

successfully by researchers on children's memory development. Their work has revealed important findings about the content, structure, and style of maternal talking that affect children's autobiographical memory and emotional development.⁶ Cultural similarities and variations have also been well documented with this method.⁷

My colleague Dr. Heidi Fung and I adopted this method and conducted a study where we recorded 209 mother-child conversations, half from European-American and half from Taiwanese families.⁸ Because both cultural groups were middle-class families, they were comparable in their socioeconomic background. We targeted early elementary school children because these children had sufficient experience of schooling where deliberate teaching and learning are the daily routine. To collect data from our simulated mother-child conversations (MCC), we asked each mother to converse with her child about two learning incidents. The first is an incident where the child showed, in the mother's judgment, good learning attitude and behavior, and the second is an incident the mother noted her child's poor learning attitude and behavior. For convenience, we use the term "good learning" for the former and the term "poor learning" for the latter. Both incidents were worded identically except that one was for good learning and the other for poor learning, as follows:

Recall an actual incident where your child showed, in your judgment, good [not good] attitudes/behavior in learning. It could be in school or outside school. The incident does not need to be something that you personally witnessed. But you should know about it in some detail to talk about it with your child. You have unlimited time to talk about this incident, and the conversation can go in any direction.

We collected a rich set of data, and it took several years of laborious effort to analyze. As for any rich data, doing full justice to them requires more time and further effort. But from what we have done, we provide a summary of the findings from three kinds of analysis: structural, sequential, and discourse. Each deals with different aspects of the data and therefore provides different insights into the socialization process. Together they enrich our understanding more than any single type of analysis. We discuss each in the following subsections.

Structural Analysis: Elements of Mother-Child Talk

The first set of analyses we performed concerns the so-called structural elements of human discourse.⁹ The elements provide a global contour of the

communication under inspection. Whereas there are many structural elements to examine, the basic ones involve turns that mothers and children took in their MCCs, the lengths such conversations lasted, and the amount of exchange that took place in MCCs. The averages of these elements for both topics were similar between the two cultural groups. Therefore, we conclude that any observed differences in the further sequential and discourse analyses were not because of the structural elements but cultural patterns of socialization.¹⁰

Sequential Analysis: How Mother–Child Talk Unfolds in Real Time

Whereas they indicate the common contour of MCCs, structural elements analyzed previously do not show how MCCs proceed with real content of conversations. It would be informative if we could peek inside the MCCs as if they were taking place right in front of us. It is true that one could just replay and listen to all 209 MCC recordings. But such listening may not help us gain greater understanding of the general patterns. A more effective approach to analyze MCCs is the so-called sequential analysis.¹¹ This approach, equipped with software used to conduct the analysis, allows tracing of steps of all 209 MCCs to be aggregated, resulting in discernable patterns by cultural group.¹²

Sequential analysis requires that naturally occurring conversations between people be coded into mutually exclusive codes. Although there are different ways to code MCCs, we chose to code our data by event.¹³ An event in an MCC is defined as a theme or a topic about which the mother and the child are talking. For example, the mother asks what learning activities the child did on a given school day. Then the child recounts the activities. Talking about learning activities here is an event. If the mother moves on to talk about how the child felt about his or her accomplishment, and the child responds with “I felt O.K. about that,” then talking about achievement-related feelings is another event. Event coding tracks who said what and what the response was; these are then aggregated over all MCCs by good-versus-poor learning and by culture. This way of coding basically converts expressed ideas, themes, and topics into frequencies of occurrence in their original sequence. Such sequenced frequencies are then submitted to computation for significance. If, say, a sequence of $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$ (where A, B, C, and D represent four different events) is found to occur beyond chance for Group 1 but not for Group 2, then this sequence is a research finding indicating a difference between the two groups. If, however, a sequence of

TABLE 7.1. *Eight sets of collapsed codes for sequential data on mother–child conversations about learning*

Code	Meaning	Examples
mP	Mother probes child positive affect	Happy, liking, pride, interested, eager, and fun
cP	Child refers to own positive affect	
mN	Mother probes child negative affect	Frustrated, disliking, sad, anger, bored, and unmotivated
cN	Child refers to own negative affect	
mV	Mother probes/instructs learning virtue	Effort, work hard, diligence, practice, persistence, dedicated, concentration, and humility
cV	Child refers to learning virtue	
mM	Mother probes learning process/mental functions	Reading, homework, research, making projects, thinking, smart, and intelligence
cM	Child refers to learning process/mental functions	

C→A→C→D is found for Group 2 but not for Group 1, then this sequence shows another difference between the two groups.

After we coded our data,¹⁴ we found that about 80 percent of codes from the two teams were highly similar in meaning. This indicates that mothers from both cultures talked to their children about similar concepts of learning attitudes and behaviors. Despite this shared conceptual space about learning, the *amount* of talking as assigned to these codes and related *sequences*, as will be seen later, differed markedly.

It is important to note that mothers in both cultural groups were not rigid in their talking regarding good-versus-poor learning. Whereas many mothers generally focused on the *positive* aspects of good learning and negative aspects of poor learning based on the topic card they drew randomly, many also moved back and forth between positive and negative aspects for both topics. We therefore were compelled to use the same codes,¹⁵ which contained both positive and negative thoughts and feelings, to code our data on both good and poor learning conversations.¹⁶

Sequential analysis required a much larger amount of data if we were to compute for more codes and longer turns. Thus, we regrouped our larger-number themes/topics into eight sets (see Table 7.1 for these themes/topics),¹⁷ with four for mothers and four for children as they took turns in

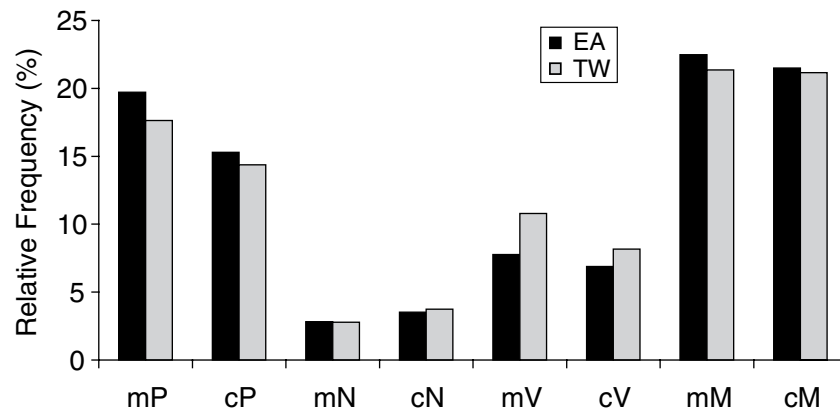


FIGURE 7.1. Eight codes for GOOD learning. mP = mother positive affect, cP = child positive affect, mN = mother negative affect, cN = child negative affect, mV = mother talks about learning virtues, cV = child talks about learning virtues, mM = mother talks about mental processes and learning activities, and cM = child talks about mental processes and learning activities.

their conversations. As can be seen, the first set of codes refers to mother and child positive affect and the second set to their respective negative affect. The third set indicates mother and child talk about learning virtues, and the fourth set deals with learning activities/mental functions (for convenience, I refer to learning activities/mental functions as simply *mental*). Finally, our data volume permitted analysis of only four turns. Thus, the sequences we computed for significance followed the pattern of mother→child→mother→child for any given theme/topic.

Before presenting the findings of sequential analysis, it would be informative to look at the general patterns of each culture's MCCs. Figures 7.1 and 7.2 show the distributions of the volume of conversations held by these two cultural groups for good and poor learning, respectively. The dark bars are European-American MCCs and gray bars are Taiwanese MCCs. Apparently, the two cultures' MCCs for good learning in Figure 7.1 did not differ much. Generally, mothers talked about mental the most, followed by positive affect and virtue, with negative affect being last. It makes sense that mothers would focus on positive rather than negative affect given that they recalled with their children a *good* learning attitude/behavior. In addition, because the mothers took the lead in their MCCs, as requested by us, they naturally talked more than their children, but their children also responded, albeit, as expected, less voluminously than their mothers. Nevertheless, it is noticeable that Taiwanese mothers and children talked more about virtue than their European-American counterparts.

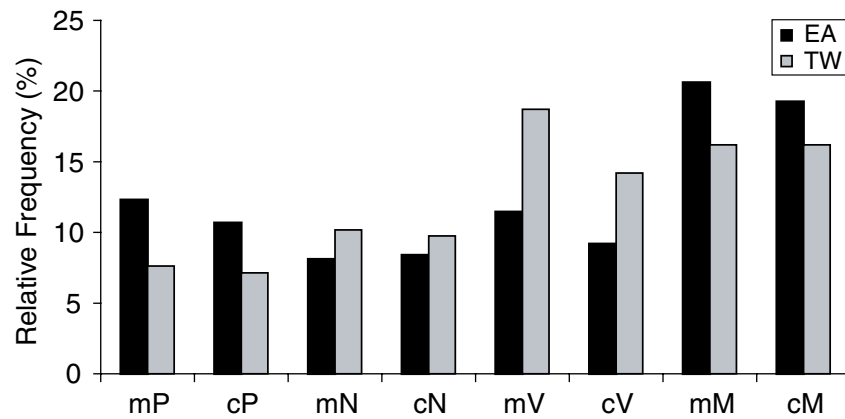


FIGURE 7.2. Eight codes for POOR learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

These trends were tested for an index called odds ratio, taking into consideration the relative amount of talk of the mothers and children within each of the two cultural groups.¹⁸ Whereas for good learning there were no statistically significant differences in the four pairs of codes between the two groups of children, there were two significant differences between the two groups of mothers. European-American mothers talked more about positive affect and Taiwanese mothers more about virtue. Specifically, European-American mothers were 20 percent more likely to talk about positive affect for good learning than Taiwanese mothers. Conversely, Taiwanese mothers were nearly 50 percent more likely to talk about virtue than their European-American mothers.

For poor learning, the distribution of MCCs in Figure 7.2 is quite different. There are significant cultural differences for every set of variables. First, European-American mothers and children still talked most about mental followed by positive affect, then virtue, and negative affect last. Taiwanese mothers talked most about virtue, and next about mental, negative affect, and positive affect last. It seems that European-American mothers stressed mental and positive affects over learning virtue. Negative affect was to be avoided. By contrast, Taiwanese mothers focused on virtue and then on mental. Unlike their European-American peers, Taiwanese mothers elaborated more on negative affect with their children. Positive affect in comparison was the least emphasized.

Tests for odds ratio further confirmed that overall, European-American mothers talked more than twice as much about positive affect and nearly 70 percent more about mental than Taiwanese mothers. European-American children were similar to their mothers (nearly 50 percent and 80 percent

more about these topics, respectively, than their Taiwanese counterparts). More pronounced than the previous pattern, Taiwanese mothers and children talked more about virtue (almost twice as much as than their European-American peers); Taiwanese children also did so nearly 70 percent more than European-American children.

In what follows, I discuss the sequential analysis that traces the turns of MCC in these two groups. To do so, I present four sets of graphs, with each comparing the European American (EA) with the Taiwanese (TW) sequences. The first four graphs show what happens when *mothers* start to talk about a given topic, how that topic is followed by their children, how mothers respond, and finally how children follow up again, with a total of four turns. The next four graphs show the same four turns with *children* as starters of the conversation.¹⁹

The statistical index is again odds ratios. Take the mother leading with positive affect as an example. We computed the odds of EA children following their mothers' talk on the same topic versus the times children did not follow their mothers but talked about something else. Then we computed the EA odds against the TW odds, resulting in an odds ratio for positive affect. Because any topic could be followed with any of the four codes, we computed odd ratios for all of them for four turns. These odds ratios enabled us to construct statistically significant turns on the graphs. Any significant sequence indicates that a group, either EA or TW, is more likely to follow a given sequence and is marked with a solid, thicker arrow in Figures 7.3–7.10. Any sequence that shows no difference between the EA and TW groups is marked with a broken line and a check mark (it is important to note that broken lines do not mean that mothers and children did *not* talk about a given topic. They could have, in fact, talked a lot – see Figures 7.1 and 7.2 for relative distributions of these topics, although the two cultural groups did not *differ* in the frequency of their follow-ups). Finally, T₁, T₂, T₃, and T₄ simply indicate the four turns.

Figures 7.3 and 7.4 show the sequences in which mothers are starters and their children's good learning is the topic. In Figure 7.3, when EA mothers begin talking about mental, their children are more likely to follow up with positive affect, not the same topic. Interestingly, as mothers begin with positive affect, their children follow up with mental as if these two topics followed each other. However, when mothers start with negative affect and virtue, their children were less likely than their TW peers to follow up with these topics. Moving to Figure 7.4, the sequences for TW differ somewhat. When mothers begin with mental, their children

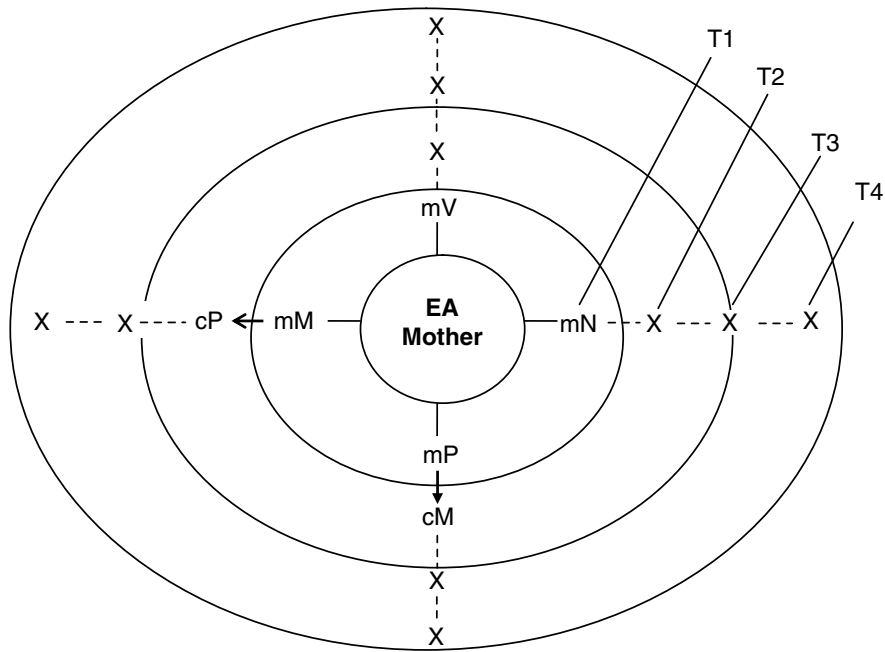


FIGURE 7.3. When European-American mothers start talking about their children's good learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

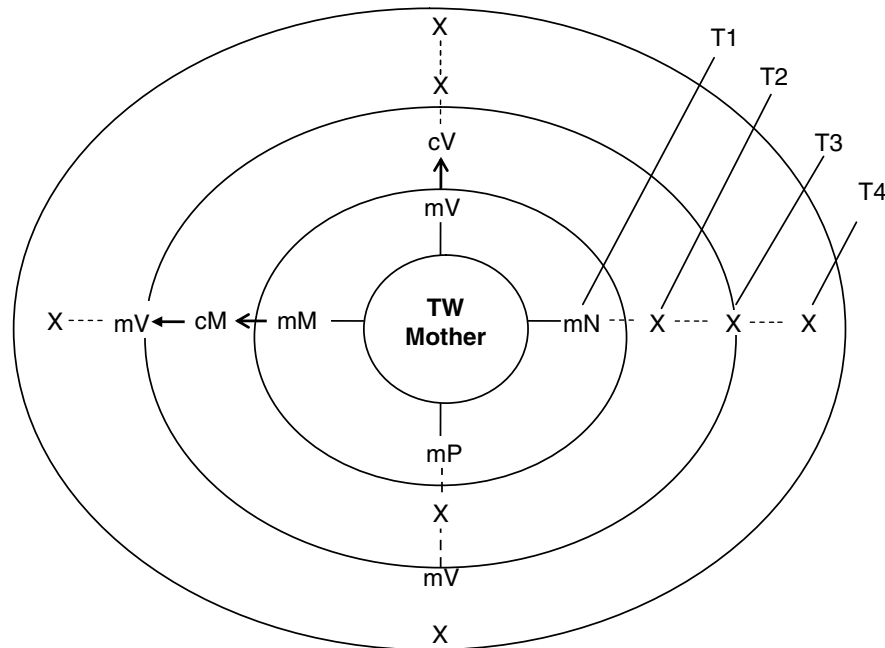


FIGURE 7.4. When Taiwanese mothers start talking about their children's good learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

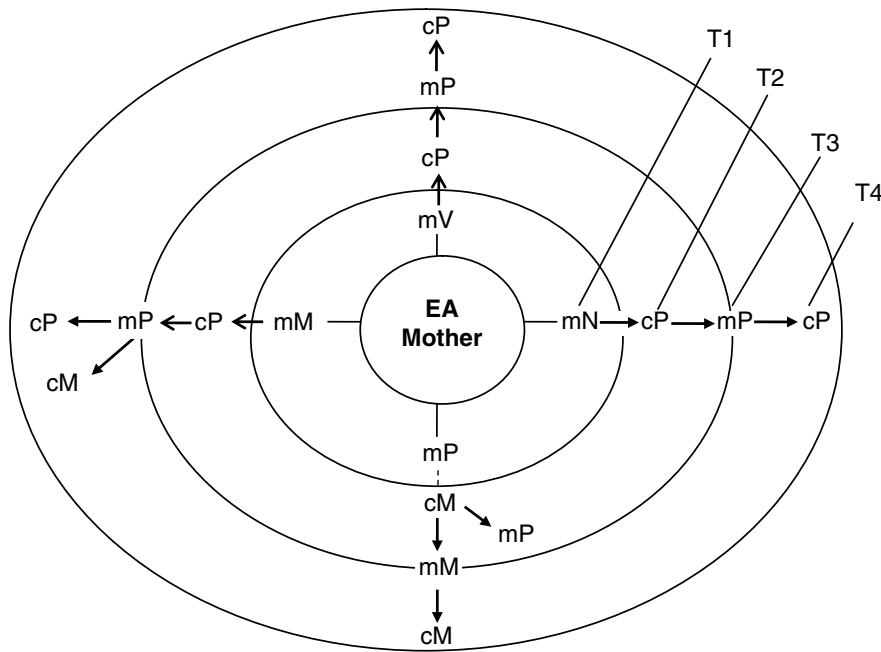


FIGURE 7.5. When European-American mothers start talking about their children's poor learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

are more likely than EA children to follow up with mental, with mothers following up further with virtue. Moreover, when mothers start with positive affect, the follow-up did not differ between the two groups' children, but in the third turn, TW mothers bring up virtue again. For mothers' starting with virtue and negative affect, TW sequences were similar to those of EA without differences.

Figures 7.5 and 7.6 show the sequences in which mothers are starters, and their children's poor learning is the topic. These sequences display the same but much more accentuated trends than the ones for good learning. When EA mothers' talk about mental, children follow up with positive affect as before, but their mothers continue to talk more about positive affect in the third turn, which is followed by children also talking more about both positive affect and mental. A similar pattern also emerges for maternal talk that opens up with positive affect. The conversational partners alternate between positive affect and mental in their turns. More striking is the fact that when mothers begin with virtue and negative affect, their children still steer the conversation into positive affect more, which is followed up by the two partners to the end again, with less likelihood of discussing mental than the TW group.

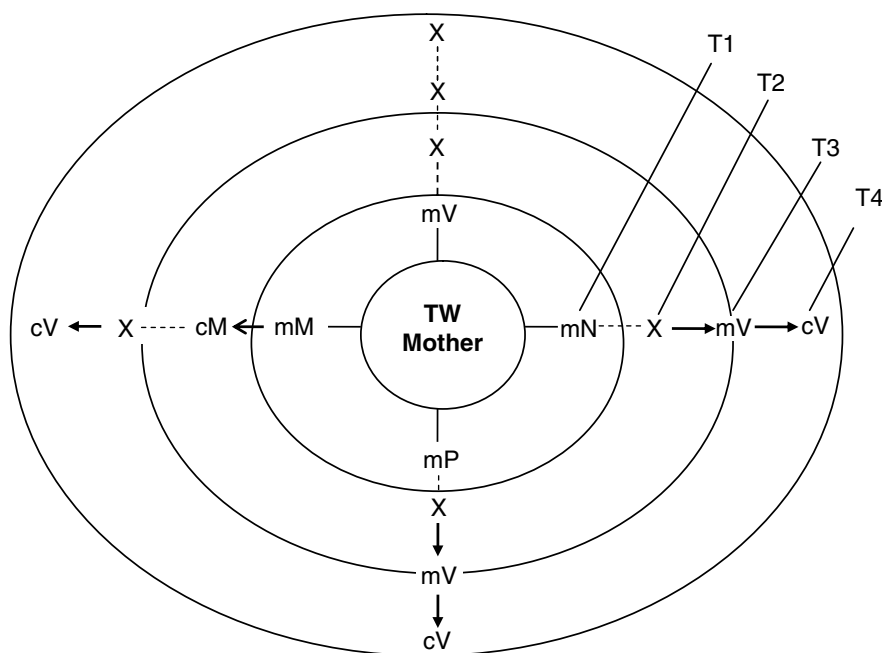


FIGURE 7.6. When Taiwanese mothers start talking about their children's poor learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

The TW graph also shows their previous trend with more emphasis. Maternal mental talk is followed with child mental talk, and then continued with maternal virtue talk. The same pattern can be seen for maternal positive affect as well as negative affect. The follow-ups of maternal virtue talk did not differ between the two cultural groups.

By now, there is less need for me to innumerate each remaining graph. Figures 7.7 and 7.8 show sequences in which children, rather than their mothers, are starters, and good learning is the topic, whereas Figures 7.9 and 7.10 show the same but with poor learning as the topic. The patterns are as expected.

Taken together, the sequential analyses compel us to conclude that mothers and children in both cultural groups talk about all four topics. Whereas the follow-ups on the topic of learning virtues itself do not differ that much between the two cultural groups, the follow-ups on the *other* three topics are quite revealing in their differences. EA mother-child conversations about learning center on positive affect and learning activities/mental functions, regardless of what topic the mother or the child brings up first. In contrast, TW conversations are mostly followed up with learning virtues, also irrespective of what topics the conversational partners begin with.

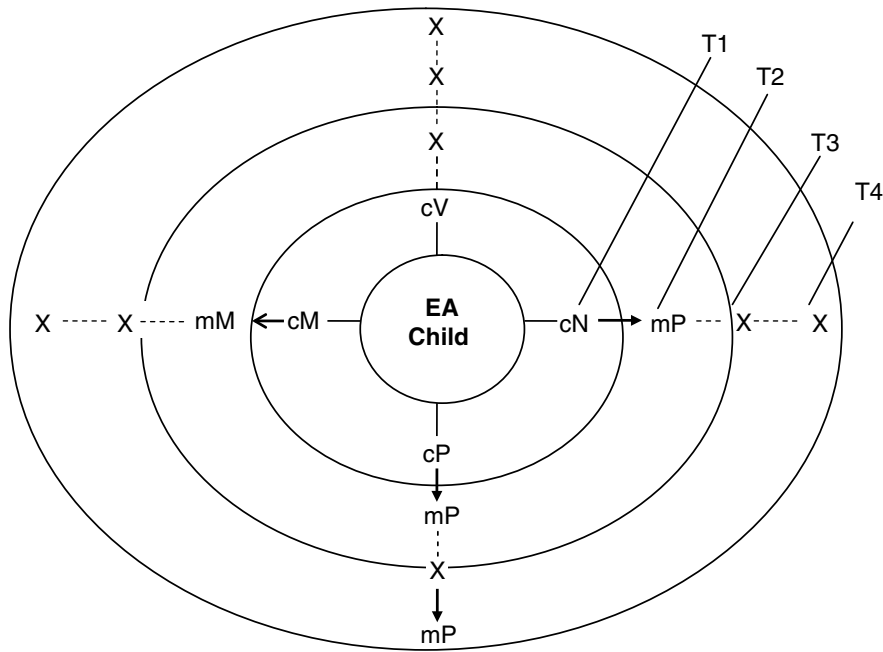


FIGURE 7.7. When European-American children start talking about their good learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

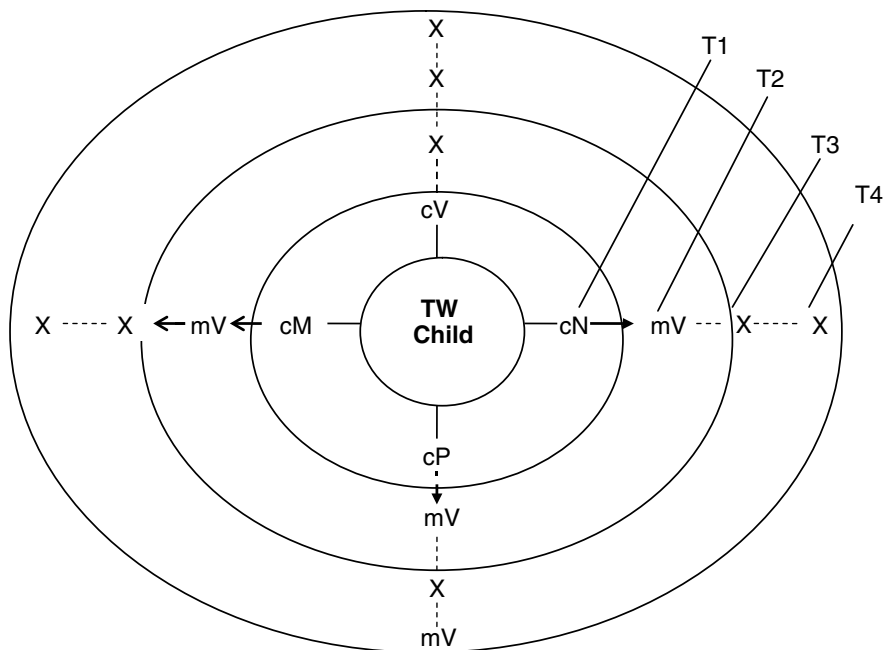


FIGURE 7.8. When Taiwanese children start talking about their good learning. The abbreviations are the same as in Figure 7.1.

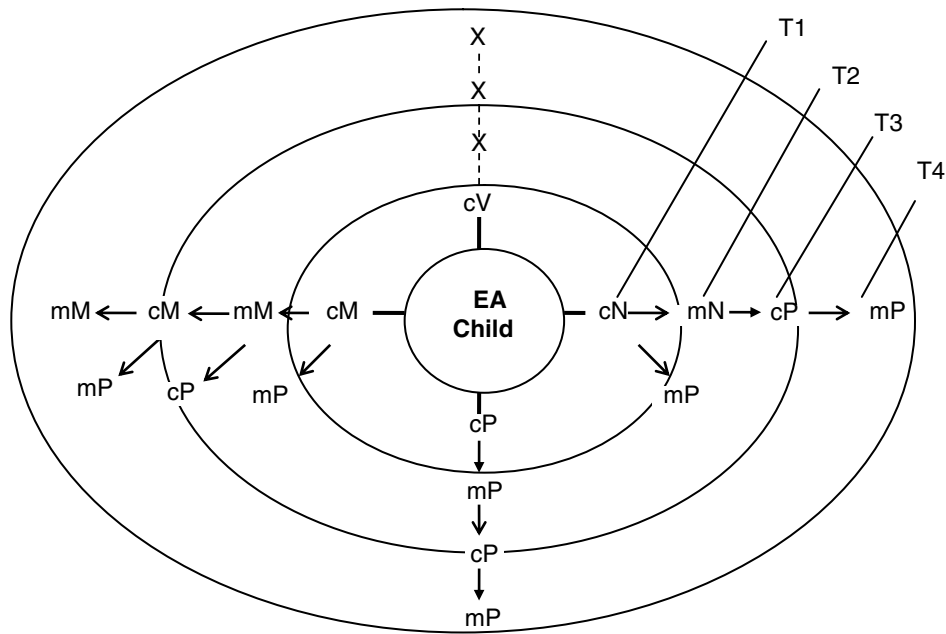


FIGURE 7.9. When European-American children start talking about their poor learning. The abbreviations are the same as in [Figure 7.1](#).

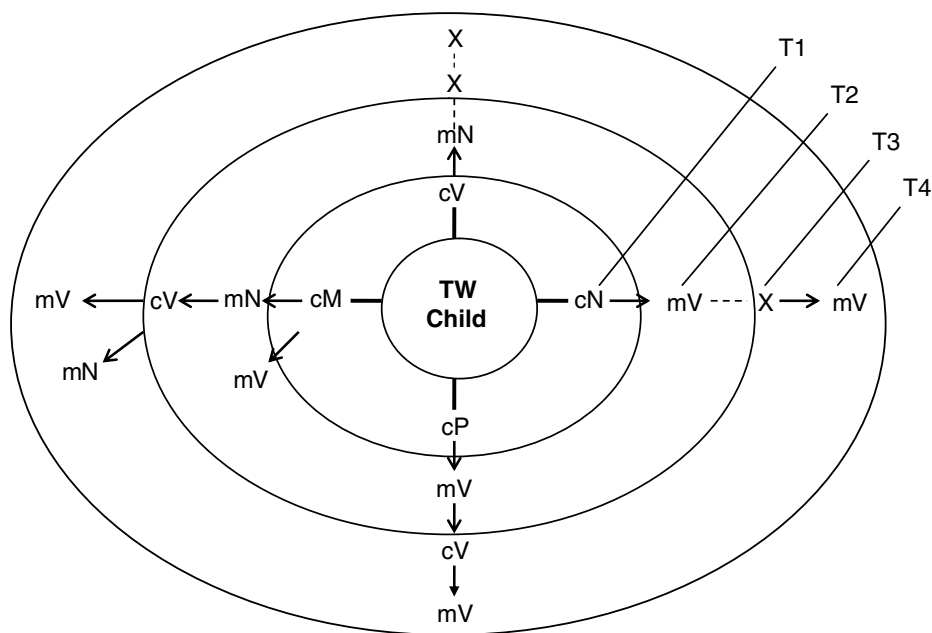


FIGURE 7.10. When Taiwanese children start talking about their poor learning. The abbreviations are the same as in [Figure 7.1](#).

Discourse Analysis: What Mothers Do with Their Talking

Discourse analysis is a well-established approach to analyzing person-to-person or group communicative processes across social settings. This approach was originally developed in sociolinguistics. Today, many education researchers and some developmental researchers prefer this approach not only to quantitative analysis, but also to some forms of *qualitative* analysis, such as behavioral observations, interviews, or traditional ethnography. Whereas traditional forms of qualitative analysis accomplish the goal of addressing the complexity of a research topic in depth, it is discourse analysis that aims primarily at understanding the speech-based communicative interactions between people.²⁰ The unique – therefore indispensable – nature of discourse analysis lies in the simple fact that many human interactions, including socialization of children, proceed via verbal communication (in conjunction with nonverbal communication). To exclude this aspect of human interaction is to miss the core of human lives and child development.

There are many types of discourse analysis that address different aspects of human speech. As a whole, however, discourse analysis pays attention to the moment-to-moment exchange between people and to the overtly expressed, but also to the subtext of the unsaid. Discourse analysis also zeroes in on what action and goal a speaker intends to achieve and how such speech acts are responded to and further shaped by participants.²¹

Both the structural and sequential analyses of the MCC data provide the basic contours and proceedings of the communication between each culture's mothers and children on the subject of good-versus-poor learning. However, because of the limitations of each type of analysis, much rich *content* of the conversations is not captured in these two types of analysis. By employing discourse analysis, we can glimpse the intricate communicative exchanges. However, because it seeks to zero in on the moment-to-moment exchange, the in-depth look of the processes, discourse analysis, unlike quantitative analysis, precludes analysis of a large number of mother-child dyads. In addition, as shown in the distribution of the eight sets of codes as part of our sequential analysis, maternal talks for good-versus-poor learning do differ in the amount of talk they engage in with their children across these codes. Still, it is more sensible to use examples from conversations in both cultural groups for discourse analysis, considering this type of analysis utilizes very detailed exchange rather than larger patterns. Thus, I present only twenty-two such exchanges from each culture in order to illustrate the

key points, recognizing the trade-off but also compensating for the different types of analysis.

There is little doubt that our near-naturalistic mother–child conversations about learning lend themselves to many kinds and layers of discourse analysis. For example, even merely looking at stylistic elements, one could examine how the two cultures’ mothers preface their MCCs with their children, how they initiate a conversation about the good-versus-poor learning incidence that actually took place, how they respond to their children’s replies, disagreements, and negotiations, and how they close the conversations. Sociolinguists delve deeply into each of these and many other aspects of communicative exchanges.²² For my purposes here, rather than trying to present exhaustive discourse analysis, it is more productive to focus on some key content of MCCs. Thus, it is beneficial to take an initial look at *what* mothers talked about, with what intentions, and how they went about achieving their goals.²³

Although my analytical focus is on cultural variations, I begin by discussing common features of the mother–child discourse that are shared by both groups. Next, I present what I see as large variations, highlighting different maternal attempts to socialize their children in learning. Hence, I focus on two topics: cognitive socialization and affective socialization.

Cognitive Socialization

Cognitive socialization here concerns the mothers’ efforts to provide maternal *mental* frames used to draw their children into a given topic. Such mental frames include, but are not limited to, how to perceive/characterize/recount the learning event/behavior to be discussed, how to explain/attribute/interpret the cause of the event/behavior, and finally how to think about future attitude/behavior. The primary theoretical guide for my analysis of cognitive socialization in these MCCs is the cognitive scaffolding or coaching as conceptualized by the Vygotskian school of thought.²⁴ Accordingly, children do not acquire skills in a vacuum and by themselves, but through the ongoing guidance from their social world. The caregivers at home are their primary guides for learning culturally valued cognitive skills. Research from this school of thought has documented clearly that a child who receives such support is likely to achieve greater cognitive development and cultural competence than a child who receives minimal social support.²⁵

Common cognitive socialization: Maternal mental frame for the child to enter. Both groups of mothers routinely set up mental frames for the events/

behaviors. Such mental frames serve to bring their children into the parental thinking mode in order to achieve mothers' purposes. The following example comes from an EA mother and her nine-year-old son Neil.²⁶ In second grade, which was a year prior to the interview, Neil received a grade P from his teacher, standing for "progressing." Despite the positive sound of the term, P in this case shows the opposite, specifically, Neil's lack of taking responsibility for his own learning. His mother decides to talk to Neil about receiving a P and the associated impact on him given that he was, in her words, a "perfectionist ... doesn't like to do things wrong."

EA Example (1)²⁷:

1. Mother (M): How did you feel when you brought home a P?
2. Child (C): Bad (whispering, but joking).
3. M: Did you expect that Mrs. Wood was gonna give you ...?
4. C: No (whispering).
5. M: Do you think that you deserved it?
6. C: Yes (whispering).
7. M: So what did you do to make – what did you do to ...?
8. C: Worked on it.

To open the MCC, the mother does not attempt to establish the fact that Neil received a P, but rather asks a direct question about how getting a P made him feel. Apparently, the mother assumes the shared knowledge and related issues of getting a P between herself and her son. This assumption holds true, because Neil answers "bad" (T2)²⁸ without any hesitation. But the observed nonverbal behavior also indicates a degree of lightheartedness about this seemingly serious topic. Next, the mother makes sure that her child is not still in a mindset to blame the teacher or someone else for getting a P. So she asks another straightforward question about whether Neil thought he deserved a P. This time he answers, albeit still whispering but no more joking – a certain "yes." The mother then moves to remind the child how he responded to a P, and Neil replies very crisply again that he "worked on it" (T8).

Although this exchange is very short, the mother succeeds in setting the mental frame effectively. Four related meanings for her son to know and to confirm are discernable: (1) she regards her son's P as a negative outcome in school; (2) this negative judgment by the teacher ought to have a negative emotional impact on the child's sense of self; (3) her son was personally responsible for getting a P; and (4) her son responded correctly to this negative outcome by trying to rectify his poor learning.

Similarly, a segment between a TW mother and her nine-year-old boy Wei on the topic of poor learning also shows the mother's attempt to set up a mental frame into which to usher her son:

TW Example (2)²⁹:

1. M: Do you remember that mom told you ... to review your school-work before you come home from school? You should look at your schoolwork to make sure that you know it well, right? Sometimes, you don't review it. What happens when your teacher gives a test?
2. C: Pretty bad.
3. M: Pretty bad, right?
4. C: Uh-huh.
5. M: Does mom scold you?
-
6. C: No.
7. M: What does mom say to you then?
8. C: I need to work harder.
9. M: You need to review the material, don't you?
10. C: Yeh!

Like the EA mother, the TW mother also brings out a negative learning outcome. Unlike the EA mother, who opens the MCC by asking a direct question on negative emotional impact of poor learning on the child, the TW mother points out the *cause* of her son's poor learning: He does not review the material taught in school (T1). Similar to the EA mother, the TW mother tries to ensure that Wei knows first the negative consequence of his failure to review schoolwork (T1). But knowing the negative consequence does not necessarily mean knowing the *cause* of poor learning because the two lie at the opposite ends of the process. This is why she attempts again with "what does mom say to you then?" (T7). When her son gives an appropriate but generic answer, "I need to work harder" (T8), the mother elaborates on a specific learning behavior: "You need to *review* the material, don't you?" (T9). In this opening short exchange, this mother, too, succeeds in making her child understand her firm belief that failure to review material taught in school leads to poor achievement.

Common cognitive socialization: Child's quibble. None of the sequences in either group have mothers expressing desires and expectations and demanding children's obedience and acceptance unilaterally, but both groups reveal much disagreement and negotiation within each dyad. In other words, the child's quibble is a rule rather than an exception. An EA

example between a mother and her seven-year-old daughter Kate illustrates this inherent nature:

EA Example (3):

....

1. M:.... So do you think when you get home from school ... is it because you want to relax and maybe have a snack or play a game or something, and you don't want to come and do some more reading, because I notice that later in the evening you get tired, so that's not really a good time to learn something new, is it?
2. C: Well, maybe if you let me have some time to like play, a little, just like for 5 or 2, 5 or 6 minutes, and let me like get used to being home for a little while, maybe I'd read like five books.
3. M: Well, we can certainly try that, that's a great idea. I didn't realize that you were feeling that way, so what we can do is try maybe having a snack and playing for a few minutes, but then what that means is...
4. C: Is you need to –
5. M: When I ask you, say it's time to do your reading homework or it's time to –
6. C: And you can't, you can't say, "Oh mom, I'll do it later, I'm in the middle of a game right now!"

....

In the prior exchange in this dyad (not shown in the excerpt), the mother first praises Kate for liking to read and then moves to point out how important it is for Kate to read not just simple books but more challenging and different kinds of books, because reading is a life-long process. After this introduction into the maternal frame, the mother hints that Kate does not like to read more. Nevertheless, the mother is also careful not to scold Kate for her lack of enthusiasm, but instead to reason with her about an external problem: timing – “in the evening you get tired” (T₁), and so it is “not a good time to learn something new” (T₁).

Despite her mother's diplomatic style, Kate picks up on her mother's critical tone and snaps back: “maybe if you let me have some time to ... play” (T₂) for a few minutes and “let me ... get used to being home for a little while, maybe I'd read like five books” (T₂). Her request does not seem unreasonable, either, given that she offers something back, namely reading five books – an outcome supposedly desired by her mother. Indeed, her mother finds her complaint reasonable, and in fact is surprised that her daughter feels deprived of relaxation time before being asked to read again

(T3). Hence, her mother agrees to try the suggestion made by Kate. But then, being skillful in maternal negotiation and never losing her parenting goal, the mother also bargains for a commitment to read from her daughter if she is to give her a break to play first. The dyad succeeds in this negotiation by the two of them jointly reaching the agreement, with the mother saying “but then ... when I ... say it’s time to do your reading homework ...” (Ts 3 and 4), and then, after the child seamlessly completes the intended maternal request, closing with “you can’t say, ‘Oh mom, I’ll do it later, I’m in the middle of a game right now!’” (T6).

Whereas it is quite common for EA authoritative parenting to engage in disagreement and negotiation with their children,³⁰ Asian parenting style has been said to be more one-sided toward parents. As such, parents are characterized as authoritarian, asserting, pressuring, and demanding without giving their children room for discussion.³¹ Our data, surprisingly, show quite the opposite. Child’s quibbles are just as prevalent for TW mother–child dyads as for EA mother–child dyads.

The next excerpt comes from a TW mother with her seven-year-old daughter Ruli, also showing disagreement between the mother and the child. After sharing with the interviewer that she can hardly find anything to complain about her daughter’s learning attitude/behavior, the mother says that the only thing she wishes that Ruli could improve upon is her impatience for writing words. No sooner does the mother open her mouth than she meets Ruli’s resistance:

TW Example (4):

1. M: When you write, you need to write slowly.
2. C: Only you are talking; I haven’t talked [referring to her mother’s prior complaining about her writing to the interviewer]!
3. M: Oh OK, it’s your turn to talk now. Please tell me then what you think you don’t do well.
4. C:... [silence for 4 sec.] Not much, none, rarely any.
-
5. M: But you’re not very serious [認真, give your 100 percent] in writing words.
6. C: I can write “I love you” though [writes].
7. M: Oh, good.
8. C: [Continues to write].
9. M: [Mother directs] then write this one, good, keep writing good.
10. C: I did it!
-

11. M: Keep writing good.
12. C: My writing is beautiful.
13. M: You think that your writing is beautiful, but you need to write seriously.
14. C: Yes, I know.

In this example, the child is not happy that her mother chats with the interviewer about her not being serious in writing; therefore, she lets her mother know that she dislikes her mother's criticism and the fact that she is not given a chance to rebut: "Only you are talking; I haven't talked!" (T2). Her mother immediately yields to Ruli's charge and invites her to talk, but she also does not let go of her parenting responsibility; hence she redirects Ruli to address her weaknesses, but this time by herself: "Please tell me then what you think you don't do well?" (T3). After some silent mulling, instead of backing off, Ruli denies that there is anything she does not do well in learning. Then, the mother reasserts her complaint "But you're not very serious in writing words" (T5). At this point, Ruli changes her strategy: she circumvents very cleverly the verbal standoff by showing her mother that she can write not only seriously and beautifully but also lovingly (T6). After successfully refuting her mother in action and obtaining her mother's acknowledgment of her beautiful writing, she declares that she knows what "writing seriously" means ("Yes, I know" T14) when her mother presses the point in the end.

Common cognitive socialization: Maternal persuasion and child alignment. Despite the prevalence of disagreement and negotiation between mothers and children, the effect of maternal socialization is clearly observable during the MCCs from both groups. It is true that not all dyads succeed equally, but most mothers tend to influence their children by persuasion and reasoning. Here I provide an example where an EA mother tries to get her eight-year-old daughter Sue to realize that not understanding math but not asking the teacher for help out of fear of embarrassment is trouble for learning.

EA Example (5):

....

1. M: So if there's something in, like, you don't really have trouble except in math so far right?
2. C: So far I don't have trouble.
3. M: Well, there were some things that you didn't understand in math.
4. C: Yeah, but the teacher made things too hard for me.

5. M: OK, so what about if something – it gets hard ... and it doesn't come easy like the rest of the stuff ... what do you think *we* [emphasis added] should do about it?
6. C: We should ...
7. M: How would anyone know?
8. C: Liz would know.
9. M: Well, but Liz wouldn't be in your class. Liz is your tutor this summer, a friend of the family. So you'd need to tell somebody.
10. C: Teacher?
11. M: The teacher? That would be a great person to tell.
12. C: Mmm.
13. M: What if you didn't feel real comfortable telling the teacher, who would you tell?
14. C: You?
15. M: And how could we, so you don't want to be embarrassed by telling the whole class that you don't know something?
-
16. C: We could talk about it privately?
17. M: How? Maybe go to school early?
18. C: OK!
19. M: And talk to the teacher?
20. C: Mm-Hmm.
-

At the beginning, Sue denies that she has any trouble in school, including math (T2). When her mother makes it clear that she does not understand some math concepts, Sue claims that it is the teacher's fault for making math too hard for her (T4). Her mother, realizing that Sue at least admits her challenge in math (even though she blames the teacher, not herself), seizes the opportunity to engage Sue in thinking about how to learn better instead of continuing to look for someone else to blame. So "what if something ... gets hard ... and it doesn't come easy ... what do you think *we* should do about it?" (T5). Notice that the mother uses "we" here, hinting to the child that overcoming this learning difficulty is not solely her task, but that of the caring and able mother as well. When Sue is at a loss in coming up with a workable idea, the mother highlights the heart of Sue's trouble: unwillingness to ask anyone for help. But instead of pushing Sue to actually ask for help, the mother skillfully switches the perspective from the receiving end of Sue's trouble: "How would anyone know?" (T7). Sue then suggests Liz, a familiar person, family friend, and Sue's tutor. But that is not where the

mother wants to guide Sue to learn. She probes now about Sue's need to tell: "So you'd need to tell somebody" (T9). Sue then comes up with what the mother desires all along – her teacher (T10). The mother is elated and welcomes Sue's willingness to ask the teacher for help (T11). But she does not stop there. Knowing that her daughter fears embarrassment stemming from telling the teacher in front the class about her difficulty with math, the mother then adeptly addresses the problem of Sue's discomfort in class (T13 and T15). In this fine attunement, Sue realizes that her mother would be a perfect intermediary between her and the teacher (T14). At this moment, the mother suggests that the best way to achieve this goal is for them to go to school early when there are no peers (T17). Then, privately, she, along with her mother, can ask for help from the teacher (T19).

This example illustrates the step-by-step guiding process in which the mother is able to change her daughter's mind from not willing to admit her shortcoming in math, to blaming the teacher, to her willingness to let others know her learning challenge, and to finding a viable solution to the problem. This mother uses careful persuasion to open her child's mind and to enable her to learn something very important in learning: It is not the actual math concept one fails to understand that matters (e.g., how to tell time on a clock, which they do discuss later in the MCC), but one's willingness to *tell* the helper what one does not know. But such willingness does not have to cost the child's self-esteem; one can find a good solution to the problem with the mother's help.

The following is an MCC between a TW mother and her eight-year-old daughter Lanyi for a similar process:

TW Example (6):

....

1. M: Your mind runs fast, and relatively speaking, this makes mom very happy, but there is one thing about you that makes me stressed out.
2. C: Uh, I write words wrong.
3. M: Oh, you already know that! Then, what do you think we should do? Would you like to make a plan? Hmm, I think that this is something you and I should negotiate.
4. C: Uh-huh.

....

5. M:.... Mom really has a headache over this thing. You give good explanations, but on your test, it's like half of the page is filled with wrong words! How'd you feel?

6. C: Where? I also have tests that are all right ... no mistakes!
7. M: If you were mom, and I were Lanyi, would you feel happy about this?
8. C: Uhh ...
9. M: If I were your kid, would you scold me?
10. C: No, I wouldn't.
11. M: Then what would you do? Encourage me, Mmm?
12. C: Yes, encourage you.
13. M: Really? Keep doing wrong, like saying "it's great that you got things wrong, how wonderful that you got wrong words?" Would a mom think like that? That would be a strange mom! I don't want to be a strange mom like that.
-
14. C: Oh, oh.
15. M: Let's have a resolve to correct this thing, can we?
16. C: Alright!
-

When the mother brings up poor achievement (T₁), luckily, Lanyi acknowledges it (T₂). However, when the mother probes, "what do you think we should do?" (T₃), she (similar to her EA peer) also uses "we" to show that she as a parent has a joint stake in her daughter's learning. The mother offers to make a plan in order to address the problem (T₃). When she tells Lanyi that she is stressed out and wants to know how Lanyi feels about such poor achievement (T₅), her daughter resists her mother and counter-argues for her good achievement (T₆). Then the mother uses a strategy to switch roles with her daughter: "If you were mom, and I were Lanyi, would you feel happy about this?" (T₇), which leads to the absurd conclusion that a mother should encourage her child to continue to do poorly in school (T₁₃). Therefore, in order to fulfill her parental duty, she must instruct her child to change. This apparently persuades Lanyi to agree that it is time to have a resolve (T₁₆) (and subsequently a plan for how to practice writing in order to prevent wrong words again in the MCC later: writing words on the wall so that both of them can see Lanyi's progress).

These six examples show clearly that it is common for both cultures' mothers to attempt to set mental frames into which to appropriate their children. But it is also common for cognitive socialization by parents to be replete with resistance and quibbles from their children. Yet, both groups of mothers succeed in aligning their children's thinking with theirs gradually by reasoning and persuasion.

Despite these commonalities, there are marked differences in cognitive socialization between the two cultures' mothers. As noted before, the

difference does not lie in whether one group's mothers set up more or fewer mental frames, but rather in the fact that their mental frames for their children are very *different*, and these frames reflect cultural orientations and priorities. Based on reiterative and cyclical reading of the MCC transcriptions, a recurrent pattern for maternal mental framing emerged with two related foci: *source* of learning and *causality* for learning. "Source" here indicates two ideas. First is the perspective that informs the mother as to how to conceptualize learning with her child. Second, "source" is also power or fund from which the mother draws legitimacy of reasoning, justification to guide, to move along, and eventually to influence the child's beliefs about learning.³² In other words, the mother is not alone in struggling to make sense of her child's learning. Behind her, there is conceptual wealth for her to rely on. This conceptual wealth is her cultural backing that provides her with both cognitive sources and resources.

Different cognitive socialization: EA maternal focus on child's mental source. More typical than not, EA mothers draw on the mental source to talk with their children about their learning, both good and poor. This tendency is more noticeable when mothers talk about their children's good learning. The following example comes from an EA mother with her seven-year-old son Ed regarding his liking to talk to his friend Bob about books in his free time, even before the teacher discusses them with class.

EA Example (7):

....

1. M: You really liked Harriet Tubman's [book] too, huh?
2. C: Mm-hmm.
3. M: And you would talk about that in your free time, too?
4. C: Sort of. Sometimes, we ... sometimes maybe.
5. M: Do you know that that's what smart people do, smart grown-ups, when they ...
6. C: Talk about books.
7. M: Yeah.
8. C: But guess what, last time when we were talking about Bunnica [children's book series], we spent *all* [emphasis added] of recess.
9. M: You're kidding?!
10. C: Really!
11. M: That's great! So that's a pretty smart thing to do, to talk about a book.

....

12. C: We read it, and ... looked up what might happen in later chapters, so that we could get a better explanation ... in our reading journals.

13. M: Oh, so you like to peek ahead sometimes when you read?
14. C: Mm-hmm.
-
15. M: [Laughing] well ... you and Bob are pretty smart readers for your age.
16. C: Mm-hmm. And we actually wanted to be ... the greatest scientists in the world!
-

This example shows clearly that the mother has in mind to steer her son into thinking that not just reading but *talking* about books is a behavior that marks very smart children and adults (T5). The mother is delighted that her son would spend his free time to talk with his friend about books (T11). This very reaction reveals that what her son and Bob do in their free time is quite unusual among children of their age, thus the exclamation “You’re kidding?!” (T9) and the admiring “you and Bob are pretty smart readers for your age” (T15). Such learning attitude and behavior are naturally deserving of praise and admiration because they are, in the mother’s view, very intelligent child behavior that bodes well for eventual adult life.

This kind of maternal guide results in the matching type of cognition on the part of the child. Notice how Ed’s response changes as a function of his mother’s steering him into smart learning behavior. When his mother initially probes about Ed’s talking about books in his free time (T3), his response is somewhat hesitant: “Sort of. Sometimes, we ... sometimes maybe” (T4). But after his mother makes it clear that talking about books is what very smart people do (T5), Ed becomes very energized and shares that his talking about books with his friend happens not just “sometimes” or “maybe” but at times takes up “*all* of recess” (T8). As his mother further affirms his good learning behavior, Ed elaborates on even more exceptional behavior, namely that he and Bob would read ahead into the chapters in order to prepare themselves with better explanations for their reading journals (T12). After the mother confirms this very impressively intelligent behavior, Ed expresses his life aspiration: “... we actually wanted to be ... the greatest scientists in the world!” (T16).

The next MCC takes place between an EA mother and her eight-year-old son Kevin, also about good learning:

EA Example (8):

-
1. C: ... someone said air and I said oxygen. So I basically was ... naming all of the categories but using a scientific [*sic.*] name for them.

2. M: Where did you learn those scientific names?
3. C: Reading different dinosaur books can tell you many things because, not only does [*sic.*] they interact with dinosaurs but ... it can actually mean the same thing with animals.
4. M: So ... reading on your favorite subject which was dinosaurs ... when you were able to use that in class and share it with your class.
5. C: But using the dinosaur names ... they also work the same for different species of things.
6. M: Mm-hmm ... so not just for dinosaurs. They work for other kinds of animals, too?
7. C: Mm-hmm.
8. M: So you were able to just use those labels for, for a bigger group of animals ... not just the dinosaurs?
9. C: Mm-hmm.
10. M: Yeah. OK ... What did Mr. West think of you being able to get the ...
11. C: He thought it was really nice. And as all the teachers had always said about me ... I had a photographic memory.
12. M: Of what?
13. C: Of many different things. It's basically ... what it basically means is one thing pops in your head ... Boom! It's not going out. Just won't leave. It's stuck in.
14. M: Uh-huh.
15. C: It's like when you take a photograph. You just can't rip the colored picture out of the frame...
16. M: Yeah. It's just stuck there. So if you ever read or heard about it, you remember it?
-
17. C: It's like a bee buzzing around in your head. You can't get it away unless you make it go away.
-

The mother helps Kevin recall a specific learning activity in class where children are learning animal names and habits. Apparently, Kevin shares his knowledge about animals he obtained from reading outside school. Kevin uses scientific terms instead of everyday words such as oxygen for air (T₁). His mother then asks him, quite typically among EA mothers, where he got these scientific names (T₂), given that his peers do not seem to know them. Kevin gives a very elaborate and sophisticated answer about how his interest in different dinosaur books benefits his knowledge base in many ways,

including his general understanding of animals: “it can actually mean the same thing with animals” (T3). However, his mother responds to his reading in general, and sharing his knowledge with class in particular, without commenting on his last and important point (T4).

Kevin knows that his mother does not quite get this point (in fact it is not clear what he means by “the same thing with animals,” which is probably why his mother fails to appreciate that idea). Thus, in T5, he states much more clearly “But using the dinosaur names ... they also work the same for different species of things.” It is upon hearing this point that his mother realizes how her son’s mind is able to take dinosaurs as one incidence and apply similar naming to other species. As such, her son has the very impressive ability to use one phenomenon to derive a generative scientific insight into other phenomena. After confirming her understanding (T6 and T7), the mother clarifies and formulates her son’s existing cognitive feat into a clearer mental principle: “So you were able to just use those labels for, for a bigger group of animals ... not just the dinosaurs?” (T8).

To signal the significance of her son’s mental achievement, she probes how his teacher reacts to Kevin’s feat (T9). Unsurprisingly, her son says that all teachers appreciate his special mental ability, one which is likened to photographic memory (T10). The remaining lines serve to establish attribution that Kevin possesses this higher ability to keep things in his head when encountering them only once. It is clear that both his mother and Kevin agree that he has an unusual mental gift for learning.

Despite different learning events, these two EA examples show mothers’ effort to shape their children’s thinking toward the mental aspects of learning. Particular attention is paid to intelligence, the mind, its functions, and mental processes. These, as discussed in the forgoing chapters, are the hallmarks of Western learning conceptions.

Different cognitive socialization: TW maternal focus on child’s virtue source. Unlike their EA counterparts, most TW mothers rely on the virtue source to provide cognitive socialization. The following segment between a mother and her seven-year-old son Ren exemplifies this tendency:

TW Example (9):

....

1. M: Oh, why does your teacher think that you behave well? ...
2. C: It’s that I concentrate well [上課很專心] in class.
3. M: Is your good concentration the concentration to talk to your peer at the next desk?
4. C: I listen to teachers.

5. M: Oh, is it so only for Mr. Chang's class or is it for all classes?
6. C: Almost all classes like that.
7. M: Oh, why do you want to be serious [認真] in class?
8. C: Oh, yes.
9. M: You could sleep while attending classes, why do you want to be serious in class?
10. C: ... if I can't answer the teacher's questions, misbehaving little friends [common term used to refer to young schoolchildren] will lose points....
11. M: Uh-ah! So you want to behave well because you want to get an ... honor award. Is that so?
12. C: Yes.
13. M: Or is it also that you yourself want to behave better?
14. C: Yes, I also want to behave better myself.
15. M: Oh, why do you want to behave better yourself?
16. C: Because my tests are pretty bad.
17. M: Okay, hmm, your tests are pretty bad?
18. C: Yeah.
-

The mother first tells Ren that she has heard his teacher say that he behaves well in school. She then asks Ren to share with her why the teacher said that (T₁). Without any hesitation, Ren responds, "It's that I concentrate well in class" (T₂). Because Ren gives a crisp claim of his virtuous behavior, which, to the mother, may seem a bit self-congratulatory, showing a less culturally valued self-portrayal, the mother asks a half-humorous question: "Is your good concentration the concentration to talk to your peer next desk?" (T₃). Ren remains cool and answers firmly that he listens to teachers, dispelling his mother's lurking doubt (T₄). But his mother still does not seem fully convinced and probes if Ren listens only to the teacher who reported Ren's good behavior (T₅). Now Ren gives an answer that seems to ring truer for his learning virtue because he does not claim concentration in *all* classes but only in "*almost* all classes" (T₆).

At this point, his mother seems to believe what he is saying. She now turns to probe why Ren displays such learning virtue and comes up with a seemingly child-friendly but actually quite prickly question, "You could sleep while attending classes, why do you want to be serious in class?" (T₉). She offers her son a way, albeit somewhat facetiously, to contemplate what it means to concentrate in class with seriousness. Ren then reports that he does not want to lose his honor award (T₁₀). However, getting an external

reward for learning virtues is not what the mother hopes, because learning virtues are moral in nature and are ends in themselves. The mother then asks if Ren also recognizes that there is a greater purpose of having concentration and seriousness in its own right beyond the extrinsic incentive: "Or is it also that you yourself want to behave better?" (T13). The child concurs (or more likely is compelled to concur) that this is also his goal (T14). Finally, the mother wants to ensure that Ren does not just agree with her superficially but sincerely by asking him to explain why he cares about making himself better (T15). Ren admits honestly his inadequacy in learning: "Because my tests are pretty bad" (T16).

This mother does not focus her socialization of her son's intelligence, ability, or mind and mental processes. In fact, throughout the segment, she never touches on this topic. Instead, she stresses the learning virtues of concentration, sincerity, and seriousness. She takes the opportunity of teacher's praise of her son to steer him toward further self-improvement. Note that this mother is talking about good learning, yet the MCC turns into probing her son's inadequacies. It would be erroneous to assume that this mother is being harsh; her son does not regard her as such. Quite the contrary, her son knows the importance of these learning virtues and cooperates with his mother. The mother's cognitive socialization lies in making her son see the point of possessing these learning virtues not for external rewards, but for his own personal growth. Later in this MCC, the mother tells her son that he is very cute because he now knows why he needs to be serious in class. Like her EA peers, she draws on the cognitive sources and resources of her culture that regards learning virtues as fundamental for learning.

In the next TW example involving good learning, the mother talks to her 9-year old daughter Jia about how to be more diligent, making further effort to self-improve in writing composition.

TW Example (10):

1. M: ... what's more, you still need to make extra effort; your composition writing needs to be strengthened. Tell me ... you go deep in reading texts, hmm, your understanding of the gist of texts is great now, and you don't even need me to teach you anymore, right?
2. C:....
3. M: A bit louder! Do you still need me to teach you or not?
4. C: No more.
5. M: No more. Now you can do it yourself; you are even better than me.... All of this comes from your own effort, right? Can you tell me how you've gotten better at writing? How do you think you improved?

....

6. C: I looked at how other people write.
7. M: Looking at how others write it. Did you not think for your own writing? How come you looked at others' writing?
8. C: I looked at what is it that they write better.
-
9. M: Oh, it's good that you know how to look at other's better writing ... that's very good. Well, then you just keep working on it, alright? But I think you also need to persist in other areas, do you know?
10. C: Alright!
11. M: How about reading? You should read more books, and this will help you write compositions later. Your teacher called. He said that you should learn more Chinese set expressions and write more.
-

In this MCC, the mother acknowledges her daughter's merit in going deep in reading texts and understanding the gist (T1) because it is about good learning. The mother is delighted that Jia has learned the skills so well that she no longer needs the mother to teach her. The mother even points out that Jia is better than herself (T5), which is significant praise in Chinese culture. However, two important cognitive goals accompany her delight. The first is making Jia understand that her writing needs further improvement, which the mother mentions before she even starts to recognize Jia's positive side (T1). This urging continues in T9: "... But I think you also need to persist in other areas, do you know?" This expression urges Jia to read more and learn more Chinese set expressions because all of this extra effort will, as recommended by the teacher, help Jia improve her writing (T11). The second goal is to lead Jia to retrieve and recount how specifically her effort enabled her to improve writing thus far: "Can you tell me how you've gotten better at writing? How do you think you improved?" (T5). Jia's response about how she looked at others' writing initially does not meet her mother's approval (probably because she suspects Jia of copying others' work) (T7). But when Jia explains that her looking at others' work is for figuring out how others write better (T8), her mother appreciates Jia's own effort (T9) to learn from others. The mother ends that point by nudging Jia to keep working on this way of learning.

This TW segment shows common Asian parental socialization for children to understand the value of diligence, extra effort, and continuous striving no matter how much the child has already achieved. Even when parents are delighted with their children's strengths and merit, they still urge them to self-improve further by exercising these virtues. Undoubtedly, these tendencies reflect Confucian learning orientation and values.

The aforementioned four examples, two from each cultural group, illustrate how mothers set up mental frames for their children by drawing on their cultural source, which is the first focus that emerged from my discourse analysis. The second maternal focus is causality for learning. Causality here is understanding the mother's *explanation* or *attribution* of what causes learning to happen, including what learning activity, attitude, behavior, or event causes what outcomes. Causality also includes reasoning about how good learning achievement comes about and how poor learning can be changed. The difference between source and causality is that the former may not offer any explanation and attribution of learning events and outcomes. But the maternal discussion still proceeds within the realm of a given source, namely cultural orientation and values.

To be sure, maternal explanations of causality in learning are not to be evaluated against traditional philosophical demarcations of logic or scientific definitions of causality. In fact, very little of what these mothers do qualify them as philosophical or scientific logicians. In actuality, parents are unlikely to care about whether their logic meets philosophical and scientific definitions when they engage in cognitive socialization of their children. Thus, I would argue that formal – and for that matter, any stringent – logic is unimportant in childrearing, if not wholly irrelevant. Nevertheless, parental logic has its own chain of reasoning, hence coherence and integrity. In parents' ways of conceptualizing the learning world, they are what might be called folk logicians. It is therefore important to analyze their own logic because it is prevalent in daily socialization, and it is undeniably efficacious and influential in child development.

Different cognitive socialization: EA maternal causality of mind potency. A common way for EA mothers to help their children understand the cause for good learning is to lead them to think about how to use their minds to achieve greatness. The following two examples demonstrate this pattern. The first features a mother and her seven-year-old son Tim.

EA Example (11):

1. M: . . . I wanted to talk to you about . . . that time when you had that one math paper that "Oh my goodness!" like mostly everything was wrong and you never bring home papers like that. Remember that one?
2. C: Mm-hmm.
3. M: And it has . . .
4. C: I just had a clumsy day.

5. M: You had a clumsy day. You sure did, but there was, when we finally figured out what it was that you were doing wrong, you were pretty happy about it.... And you were very happy to know the right way to do it, and then you were very happy to practice it. Right?
6. C:....
7. M: ... cause at first remember I looked at it and I couldn't figure out why you were coming out with the answer ... and you were having a tough time explaining it to me. Right? Yea, and once we figured it out you were pretty happy that I figured it out. And then ... I gave you a whole big paper with lots and lots of problems on it just so you could practice, and so I could make sure you really understood it. And you did the whole thing lickety split; you got everything right, and you did it with a smile on your face ... you were very happy about it. Why do you think that was?
8. C: I don't know, because I was frustrated, and then you sat down and went over it with me, and I figured it out right with no distraction, and then I got it right.
9. M: So it made you feel good to do well?
10. C: Uh-huh.
11. M: And it's OK to get some wrong sometimes, right? Cause ...
12. C: And I, I never got that again, didn't I?
-

Note that this MCC is about good learning. However, the learning experience that the mother brings up first is a negative one (T1). But very quickly, she turns the negative to the positive: "but ... when we finally figured out what it was that you were doing wrong, you were pretty happy about it.... And you were very happy to know the right way to do it" (T5). In T7, the mother elaborates on the process of discovering Tim's problems with math because he had "a tough time explaining" to her. Subsequently, she used her mind to figure out what it was that Tim did wrong and made sure that he understood it. Once she found the "cause" of Tim's difficulties, Tim's problem was solved, which made him happy and motivated to do "lots and lots of [math] problems" that were created by the mother for him to practice on. In the same turn, the question at the very end, "Why do you think that was?" serves to highlight the maternal explanation of causality for turning Tim's negative learning experience into a positive one. Tim recounts the chain of events (T8). The mother generalizes this learning experience into a normative expectation: "And it's OK to get

some wrong sometimes, right?” (T11). Tim offers a happy closure to this exchange (T12).

The reasoning train for causality can be written in the following steps:

1. Tim is initially frustrated about not knowing how to do his math problems.
2. Mother discovers this problem.
3. Mother sits down with him and uses her mind to figure out what he fails to understand.
4. Mother makes sure that he understands it.
5. Mother creates practice problems for him to do.
6. He does all of them right.
7. He feels happy.
8. He never did math wrong again.

Whereas all of these steps are regarded as causal for the mother and the child, the most essential causal link is (3), where the mother uses her mind to figure things out and to show her son and to make him understand. Without (3), Tim would not have understood the math and would not have regained his motivation. Thus, the maternal belief about causality for good learning is built on the potency of the mind to figure things out and to understand.

The next example, a segment between a mother and her eight-year-old daughter Nina, also highlights the mental as the key causality for learning:

EA Example (12):

1. M: ... but I like that you ... do the research part and do it correctly, and you read the books you're supposed to read, so that you know ... what you're doing. And you get ideas about how you want your project to shape up. And ... that's really important to the planning part. It's important ... because if you just rush ahead and do the project without the information, it's not gonna come out very well as it. ...
2. C: And you'll be lying, pretty much.
3. M: Well ... you'd have to make up the facts if you didn't really do the research, right?
4. C: Uh-uh.
5. M: But, when you do the research, you're armed with the knowledge that you need ...
6. C: Especially if you take notes.
7. M: You take notes to make sure you can verify your facts, right?
8. C: 'Cause if you don't take notes, you'll forget. And then, you'll end up making up stuff again.

The mother first mentions to the interviewer that Nina has high enthusiasm about schoolwork. She jumps in full of excitement, but quickly loses her motivation. However, the mother finds Nina's approach to doing her research to be very good. In T₁, the mother lays out her reasoning for causality for Nina's good research work. She emphasizes that doing all the research is "really important," because without obtaining the information, Nina's project will not "come out very well." Knowing the implications of her mother's reasoning, Nina fleshes out an even graver consequence that is not mental but moral in nature: "And you'll be lying" (T₂). The mother's follow-up explanation brings Nina back to a more mental causality: "Well ... you'd have to make up the facts if you didn't really do the research, right?" (T₃). In T₅, the mother offers the causal antidote for combating the problem of not having the needed knowledge: doing your research. Nina, being in harmony with her mother's reasoning, comes up with the specific activity of taking notes for research (T₆). Her mother further reiterates her main point of verifying facts in order to avoid the situation of having to make up facts (T₇). Her daughter, now completely aligned with her mother's reasoning, reaffirms the ultimate benefit of doing research, taking notes, and getting information in order not to "end up making up stuff again" (T₈).

Here again, the mother's causal explanation of doing research right is to prevent her daughter from having to make up facts. When her daughter hints at the moral consequence of lying, the mother skillfully steers her back to the mental, because not doing research right may not be a moral transgression but the mind's failure. What may cause Nina to have to fabricate facts is her waned motivation and rush through research, not moral failure. What the mother needs to do is to reason with her daughter about a mental process for how to do her research right. This segment demonstrates again the weight of mind and mental processes in maternal causal thinking about children's learning.

Different cognitive socialization: TW maternal causality of: virtue potency. TW mothers use a different causality to explain and to attribute their children's learning. Their focus is on the power of learning virtues. The following example takes place between a mother and her eight-year-old son Ming.

TW Example (13):

1. M: My boy, I'd like to talk about your swimming because I think that you are great at swimming. Am I right?
2. C: Uh-uh.
3. M: Yes, you are very good at swimming, but why did you say you were scared, afraid of touching water? How come you were not afraid of water anymore later?

4. C: I don't know.
5. M: ... Uh? Now there is another kid who is also afraid of water, how'd you help him, uh? If he is also afraid of water, but he also really wants to swim, how'd you help him, uh? ...
6. C: I think ... I'd first teach him how to hold breath ...
-
7. M: ... I think that you are great at swimming, how did you overcome that ...?
8. C: It was the coach ... who taught me how to hold breath ...
9. M: But initially you didn't want to get into water ... how come you wanted to learn then?
10. C: Because ... it's fun in the water ...
-
11. M: That was why you make an effort to learn! But how about your fear of water, how'd you overcome that?
-
12. C: That I don't really know.
13. M: Were you afraid at the beginning?
14. C: At the beginning ... I was very afraid.
15. M: How did you become less and less afraid?
16. C: Because ... I learned how to hold my breath.
17. M: Uh-ah! Someone taught you, right? You knew how to do it, you used it, then you weren't afraid anymore, right? Then you practiced and practiced, and then you got better and better, right?
18. C: That's right!
19. M: OK, did you feel like too hard [辛苦exhausted] to practice holding breath at the beginning?
20. C: Not really.
21. M: How can that not be hard [exhausting]?! Then, is it hard [exhausting] to learn other things?
22. C: Yes, how can it not be hard?
23. M: So, can you be lazy?
24. C: No ... no!
25. M: Then other things ... don't you think that you need to make more effort, not be so lazy ... would you?
26. C: OK, OK ...
-

This somewhat lengthy segment shows how a TW mother accomplishes reasoning with her son that learning virtues are the real cause for good

learning. Not only do they help the child overcome challenges such as fear, lack of motivation, unwillingness to practice, and falling into laziness, but they also are the general principles for learning anything.

The mother begins by affirming Ming's swimming skills (T1). But instead of just praising him, the mother wants him to know the underlying cause of his achievement. So she immediately asks him to think about how he changed from fearing water to not fearing water anymore (T3). When Ming says he does not know (T4), the mother sets up a concrete scenario of a peer who fears water but also wants to swim (just like Ming at the beginning) for Ming to tap the real cause of his learning (T5). Instead of getting into learning virtues, however, Ming mentions a technical skill, "holding breath" (T6). Apparently, his mother is not satisfied with his response and probes further (T7), but Ming gives an even more technical recount of learning the technique from the coach (T8). Seeing that her son is not going where she wants him to go, the mother asks about his motivation for why he wanted to learn (T9). Ming, being a typical child, mentions fun as his initial motivation (T10). Because Ming is drifting further from learning virtues, the mother simply connects Ming's desire for fun to the necessity of making a great effort to learn: "That was why you make an effort to learn!" (T11). Right after this causal link, the mother probes again how effort was responsible for helping Ming overcome his fear of water in the same turn. But Ming does not seem to quite get his mother's idea any further. After a few back-and-forth turns, his mother seizes Ming's idea that the coach successfully taught him and elaborates a series of reasoning steps in T17: "Uh-ah! Someone taught you, right? You knew how to do it, you used it, then you weren't afraid anymore, right? Then you practiced and practiced, and then you got better and better, right?" She finally makes Ming see her point "That's right!" (T18).

It would not be worthy of such a discussion if what Ming did just applies to swimming. The mother wants Ming to know how learning virtues are the real cause and guarantee for everything worthy of learning beyond swimming. Therefore, she acknowledges that working hard is hard/exhausting (T19). But Ming does not think learning how to hold breath is that hard (T20). The mother then categorically denies Ming's dismissal of the necessary price learning entails (T21) and moves on to ask him to think about learning in general in the same turn: "Then, is it hard [exhausting] to learn other things?" Now, Ming has completely entered his mother's causal frame and concurs with her: "Yes, how can it not be hard?" (T22). Finally, his mother returns to the issue that she mentions to the interviewer prior to the MCC, namely that Ming does not make enough effort in learning despite being very bright – "So, can you be lazy?" (T23) – followed by Ming's

agreement (T24). The mother ends her probing by extending more effort (i.e., not be lazy) into a general virtue for any learning (T25).

The reasoning chain of this TW mother can also be written in the following steps:

1. Ming is initially afraid of water, but he wants to have fun.
2. He is willing to learn how to swim.
3. Someone teaches Ming some techniques.
4. He masters them, which helps him overcome his fear.
5. But mastery is only possible with much practice.
6. The more he practices, the better he gets.
7. Hard work is necessary to learn how to swim.
8. Ming cannot be lazy in learning how to swim.
9. Hard work is required for any learning.
10. Ming cannot be lazy in learning anything.

Similar to the reasoning steps EA mothers take to socialize their children, all of these steps are regarded as causal by the mother. But the most important ones are (5), (6), and (9) because they are the true purpose of this TW mother's socialization effort.

The next MCC segment, featuring another TW mother with her nine-year-old son Wei, follows these essential causal reasoning steps, albeit in shorter and simpler forms.

TW Example (14):

....

1. M: I thought that the best thing to do was for you take initiative ... to hurry to learn how to play [Beethoven's] "Für Elisa!"
2. C: Mm-hmm.
3. M: Then you made a great effort to practice it, right?
4. C: Uh-uh.
5. M: Well, Ms. Jin didn't want to teach you anymore because she said that your hands were too small, not big enough to play, right? But you insisted on practicing yourself, one segment at a time. In the end it got really hard; then you told Ms. Jin that you had already practiced everything well, but the last segment you couldn't do. Then Ms. Jin agreed to teach you, which made you really happy, didn't it?
6. C: Yes.
7. M: Then you came home, and you practiced and practiced, with lots of energy. Mom didn't even need to urge you anymore. You did it on your own, didn't you?
8. C: Yeah.

9. M: Then you entered a competition with this piece, right?
10. C: Yes.
11. M: Last week you got the No. 1 prize, did you not?
12. C: Yes, I did.
13. M: Therefore ... therefore mom keeps telling you “as thou sow ...”
14. C: So you shall reap.
15. M: You shall reap, right?
16. C: Right.

The mother recounts most of Wei's learning virtues while he confirms his mother's reasoning. To her mind, the only causality of Wei's winning the No. 1 prize was his self-initiated, persistent, undaunted tenacity in practice. Because the mother admires and is so moved by Wei's learning virtues, he does not need to say much. But when his mother endeavors to distill a general learning virtue out of Wei's good learning with “as thou sow,” Wei joins her in completing the coda: “So you shall reap.” This is as if they were singing a duet, with the mother singing the main tune and Wei complementing it. Together they present the song of learning virtues.

In sum, these four MCC examples, two from each culture, demonstrate clearly from where each group of mothers draw their understanding of causality of good learning. They use this understanding and conviction to socialize their children. More often than not, children move closer to the intended influence of their mothers. The potency of each culture's learning orientation is revealed.

Affective Socialization

Affective socialization concerns parental efforts to guide their children in their affective responses to learning. They do so based on their beliefs for how their children should feel about their own learning. Intuitively, one might think that emotion/affect in general is something that simply happens to us spontaneously and may not be subject to human volitional control. Indeed, some very basic human emotions may be quite automated and universally experienced; for example, a sudden and loud boom is likely to startle most human beings, regardless of their cultural origin. However, as discussed in [Chapter 5](#), even such a basic emotion requires appraisal, that is, cognitive assessment before our body can respond to the stimulus, even if such appraisal may happen in a split second. Most other, particularly socially generated, emotions are likely to require more and longer appraisal. The more socially complex a given emotion is, the more complex cognition is likely required for appraisal.

As noted in [Chapter 5](#), the appraisal process involved in human emotional response is judgment that our minds make to determine the significance of the event. As Frijda's³³ theory describes, we first register, code, and appraise the given event in order for us to know if it is positive or negative, benign or adverse, and so forth. Only after such appraisal is done can our body respond emotionally to the event.

Because appraisal is evaluative, it is bound to be sociocultural in nature. We cannot judge and evaluate the significance of an event neutrally. To appraise an event is to appraise it according to our culturally defined meanings and significance. This is why we observe that a given event may be appraised as an insult in one culture but as a friendship overture in another. For this reason, much of *how we feel* in fact comes about by our cultures socializing us *how to feel* during the long developmental process of our lives.³⁴ To borrow Kenneth Gergen's³⁵ insight, our physiological capacity to emote is likely only an instrument for achieving our culturally organized ends.

From this standpoint, how children feel in learning is also, to a significant degree, subject to and indeed under parental socialization. As such, children's affective responses to learning are far from spontaneous and "natural," but are colored by their parents' ethnotheories³⁶ about how best to feel – that is, their culturally informed beliefs. Indeed, John Gottman and colleague proposed parental emotion socialization as guided by their "meta-emotion philosophy" that shapes parental awareness, acceptance, and coaching of their children's emotion.³⁷ Similar to this new conceptualization, Nancy Eisenberg and colleagues define socialization of emotion as

behaviors enacted by socializers that (a) influence the child's learning ... regarding the experience, expression, and regulation of emotion and emotion-related behavior, and (b) are expected to affect the child's emotional experience, learning of content, and emotion-related behavior in a manner consistent with socializers' beliefs, values, and goals about emotion and its relation to individual functioning and adaptation in society.³⁸

Subsequent research has documented that parental emotion socialization indeed influences children's physical health, socioemotional competence, learning motivation, academic achievement, and peer relations among infants/toddlers, preschool children, and elementary schoolchildren.³⁹

Surely, in the MCCs, mothers commonly discuss affective responses in learning with their early elementary school children. They talk about how a given learning activity or experience makes their children feel or

how children's affects influence their learning engagement and outcome. But more importantly, mothers stress how a learning activity *ought* to make their children feel and how children's affect *ought* to shape their learning. If children seem not to align initially with their mothers, it is usually the case that the mothers will make the children align.

Common affective socialization. Undoubtedly, there are commonalities between the two cultural groups in the maternal effort to socialize their children's learning-related affect. The following segments, one from each culture, provide examples, with the first from an EA mother and her eight-year-old son Tom on the subject of good learning:

EA Example (15):

....

1. M: And did you enjoy that part of it?
2. C: Yeah, and Mom, we also got some extra details.
3. M: We did, we got extra details, yep.... So ... when you came home and showed daddy, what did he say, do you remember?
4. C: No.
5. M: He said [in a goofy voice], "how come you didn't get me involved in this, cause I'm the scientist!" Remember? He was jealous, wasn't he?....
6. C: [Giggles] I did it just to get through with my homework.
7. M: But ... so what do you enjoy about science?
8. C: Hmm ... [silence, 3 sec.]
9. M: You enjoy knowing how things work, right?
10. C: Yeah.

....

Before this segment, the mother helps the child recall a good learning incidence where Tom made, with his mother's assistance, a nice wind sock to hang on the tree as his science homework. They searched on the Internet for information. Then, at the beginning of the preceding segment, the mother changes the factual recollection to emotional probing (T₁). The particular affect that the mother wants her son to savor is enjoyment. However, that does not seem to catch Tom's attention initially, so he still talks about the details from the Internet (T₂). His mother responds a bit more (T₃) but turns back to the affective impact of Tom's work on his dad (T₃), showing how Tom's good learning made both his parents happy. But Tom does not remember that (T₄). At this juncture, his mother uses dramatic reenactment to elaborate on the positive affect involving his dad (T₅). This makes Tom giggle, but he does not seem to join his mother's excitement fully and

returns to the fact that he just tried to get through his homework (T6). His mother is unaffected by Tom's apparent lesser excitement and continues to ask him what he enjoys about science (T7). When Tom seems to be at a loss for words, his mother supplies a response with a rhetorical question at the end: "You enjoy knowing how things work, right?" Finally, Tom concurs with his mother, helping end the segment.

This segment shows clearly how the mother intends to link her son's science homework to his enjoyment. Clearly, her son is initially quite neutral about this link. Even when his mother becomes very excited herself and later brings up his father's enthusiasm with dramatic reenactment, Tom remains somewhat slow in catching up with his mother's effort to socialize him in feeling enjoyment about his homework. However, his mother does not give up and continues to probe him until he becomes more aligned with her purpose.

The next segment is between a TW mother and her eight-year-old son Sheng, also involving good learning:

TW Example (16):

....

1. M: You got your new belt, didn't you?
2. C: Hm-hmm.
3. M: Uh-huh, so would that make you think that I will ... try to get that victorious feeling back and apply it to other times ... you can also ... achieve the same thing, right?
4. C: Yeah ...

....

5. M: I thought that you were a little afraid when you just began ...
6. C: Mm-hmm.
7. M: I remember that in the morning right before the test, you were a little afraid, right? Then what did mom tell you how you should feel?
8. C: Courageous!
9. M: Yes, yes, then what should you try to show?
10. C: My power!
11. M: Power, yeah, did you show it?
12. C: Yes, I did ...

....

The mother talks to Sheng about achieving his new belt for taekwondo by overcoming his initial fear. Apparently, his mother coached him for better affect, which the mother believed to be the condition for his success.

After helping Sheng recall this event (T1), the mother asks Sheng if he has thought about applying his victorious feeling to other taekwondo competitions (T3). Sheng says yes. Having obtained Sheng's agreement, the mother now goes back to Sheng's initial fear (T6). With his admission, the mother then asks him directly what she said to him about how he *should feel* (T7). Unequivocally, Sheng responds "courageous!" (T8). She probes further for how Sheng should manifest his courage. He supplies "my power!" (T10) and tells his mother that he showed it in action (T12).

In this segment, the affect that the mother hopes to socialize her son in feeling is courage to overcome fear and to generate power to display in his competition. Once successful, her son should hold on to the sense of victory and apply it to later competitions. Evidently, the mother has in mind how her son should feel when he feels fear and when he achieves success. Like her EA peer, this TW mother is also skillful at linking obstacles and outcomes of learning to the affects that she believes are important for her son to feel.

As for cognitive socialization, there are large differences in affective socialization between these two groups. My analysis yielded two distinct foci in maternal affective socialization: affect involved in the learning *process* and affect about *achievement*. These two cultures' mothers talk about different affects for both. In what follows, I present two examples for affect in learning process and one example for achievement for each group.

Different affective socialization: EA maternal focus on interest and fun. Consistent with discussions in previous chapters, particularly in [Chapter 5](#), EA mothers focus much more on how to cultivate and acknowledge their children's interest, curiosity, and fun in their learning process and how such learning enables the child to learn better. The following example takes place between a mother and her seven-year-old son Evan.

EA Example (17):

....

1. M: Do you think it's interesting to learn about math?
2. C: No, not really.
3. M: What if math was like, you know, instead of what's 7 plus 5, what if it was like, there were 7 frogs, and 5 frogs hopped over to visit them, how many frogs were there all together? Would that be more interesting?
4. C: Well yeah, I'd be more interested, but ... I still wouldn't really like it.

5. M: Would you rather ... see a problem that said 7 plus 5, or would you rather see a little story saying there were 7 frogs, and 5 frogs hopped over, which would be more interesting to you?
6. C: The frog, like the 5 frogs and some hopped over, that one.
-

This segment follows much discussion on the fact that Evan likes to learn about frogs and tadpoles because he is fascinated by them (not shown). Apparently, the mother wants to bring her son to a different realm of learning, that of math, which she knows her son does not like (T1). She adeptly takes Evan's original interest in frogs to explore his interest in math (T2). But Evan only inches a bit in the maternal direction; he still rejects liking math (T3). Then, the mother comes up with a different and very clever suggestion about hearing a story about frogs hopping and visiting others rather than the dry abstract addition with numbers (T5). She successfully moves Evan to liking this way of learning math (T6).

The next segment shows how a mother probes her eight-year-old daughter Shelley about her fun in doing her project.

EA Example (18):

-
1. M: You were learning things but it was fun, wasn't it?
2. C: Yeah.
3. M: ... do you think it's better when you're doing things ... that like having a play or something, do you think that's better to learn than sitting there and reading a book? Do you think it's more fun, or do you think you learn more, you just think it's just more fun?
4. C: I think it's better to learn ...
5. M: You think it was easier to learn, when you're ... speaking your lines, going over the lines every day.
6. C: Yeah.
7. M: Cause I'm sure, you going over those lines every day, doing the play, I betcha you would remember more than just reading it in the book once or doing a little essay about it.... Don't you think?
8. C: Yeah.

Like Evan's mother, Shelley's mother wants her daughter to think about what role fun plays in her learning – why she separates learning from fun for Shelley (T1). However, Shelley's simple response ("Yeah," [T2]) does not quite get at what her mother has in mind. So she juxtaposes the more fun way of learning and just "sitting there and reading a book" and then

contrasts “just more fun” versus “learn more?” (T3). Shelley understands her mother’s sophisticated probing and acknowledges “it’s better to learn” (T4). The mother further points out how fun helps make learning specific things easier (T5) and helps Shelley remember more things than without fun (T7). Shelley fully concurs.

Different affective socialization: TW maternal focus on pain but perseverance. TW mothers sometimes also talk to their children about their interest, liking, and fun. More often, however, their focus is on their belief that there are difficulties, hardship (bitterness, 苦), and therefore pain in learning anything well. Therefore, they coach their children on how to overcome such inherent challenges. They rely heavily on unequivocal learning virtues. The following example, involving a TW mother and her nine-year-old daughter Hua, is on unavoidable pain in learning:

TW Example (19):

....

1. M: Hmm, would you like to become a natural scientist later on?
2. C: No.
3. M: Why? Didn’t you say you like that?
4. C: Yeah, but I feel that would be so much hard work [很辛苦].
5. M: Not so, you will learn a lot.
6. C: I don’t want it.
7. M: Uh, there is delight in hard work! [辛苦中有快樂啊!].
8. C: I don’t like it.

....

Before this segment, the mother talks to Hua about her liking and interest in her class about nature. But Hua says that there is one thing she does not like about that class – the teacher is too strict. The mother then changes that topic to the possibility of Hua becoming a natural scientist because she really likes nature (T1). But Hua does not share her mother’s career aspiration (T2). The mother takes Hua’s own interest in nature and questions her denial (T3). Hua confirms that she does indeed like nature but does not like so much hard work in science (T4). Her mother uses a typical East Asian reasoning that hard work yields much learning (T5). Hua goes back to her not wanting to work hard. The mother then appeals with “delight in hard work” (T7), a set phrase in Chinese frequently cited in daily communication. Unfortunately, Hua would not budge (T8).

Although Hua ultimately is not convinced by her mother’s affective socialization (amid cognitive socialization), this fact does not deter her mother from attempting and persisting. She acknowledges hard work as

inherent reality in science learning and presses Hua to adopt the view that there is delight in hard work. Similarly, recall TW Example 13, where Ming's mother also brings up the notion of pain (exhaustion in practicing swimming) during T₂₁–T₂₄. When Ming denies hard work, his mother pleads “How can that not be hard?!” (T₂₃).

The following segment between a TW mother and her seven-year-old daughter Wenyi addresses how pain in learning can be combated:

TW Example (20):

....

1. M: ... why did you feel it hard to spell words, but now you feel easy? Before you were afraid of Chinese, and you didn't like it, but why did you change to liking it now?
2. C: ... because I did well on my tests, and I understand the teacher in class, so I like it now.
3. M: That's why mom urges you to hold on to persistence toward things ... the attitude, you need to have seriousness toward learning anything, not afraid of difficulties, don't I?
4. C: Yes.
5. M: Like you were afraid of the standard sound of Chinese ... right?
6. C: Mm-hmm.
7. M: Mm-hmm, when you began learning the spelling, you understood your teacher sometimes but not other times. But after a while, you got it; then you weren't afraid of it anymore. This is for sure an achievement.
8. C: Mm-hmm.

....

This segment shows how the mother links Wenyi's success in learning standard Chinese spelling to her persistence. Actually, from T₂, it is not clear whether Wenyi really persisted. In fact, it seems that she just got lucky on her tests despite her lack of understanding the teacher well. What is clear is that Wenyi did well on her tests, and then she began to understand the teacher, which made her like learning Chinese. But ascertaining the facts is not the point her mother wants her to understand in this segment. Instead, she wants to attribute (or to be more accurate, fit) Wenyi's success to her holding on to persistence, which, in her mother's conviction, enabled her not only to learn Chinese spelling but more broadly to face any difficulty in learning (T₃). A specific persisting behavior the mother demonstrates next is to hang in there, being patient and serious for enough time, until Wenyi tastes some success. The mother highlights this moment by connecting it to

no more “afraid of it,” which she unambiguously declares as a sure achievement (T7). Wenyi, like her EA peer, concurs with her mother.

Different affective socialization: EA pride for achievement. The second focus of maternal affective socialization is response to achievement. EA mothers in general emphasize pride more than any other emotion (the importance of pride in the West is discussed at length in [Chapter 5](#)). Here is an example of a sequence taking place between an EA mother and her eight-year-old son Ian regarding good learning.

EA Example (21):

1. M: Oh cause it was something you really liked ... because everyone was impressed ...
-
2. C: Mrs. Bernard looked at you when I was finished ...
3. M: Oh cause she looked at me.... So you wanted us to be proud.
4. C: Hmm-hmm.
5. M: Or you wanted to be proud of yourself?
6. C: Yeah.

Ian likes Shakespeare’s *Romeo and Juliet* (part of the sequence not shown in the excerpt). When students were assigned to give a presentation on this story, Ian showed high enthusiasm. He asked his dad to help him gather information and did an “excellent job” with it and gave a great presentation. This segment is about what happened after Ian did all of that. The mother recounts that “everyone was impressed” (T1), and Ian tells his mother that the teacher looked at his mother when he was done with his presentation (T2). All of this is interpreted by the mother as a moment for parental pride (T3). But parental pride is only one part of the affective response to Ian’s achievement; the child himself also *should* be proud of *himself* (T5), with which Ian agrees (T6).

Different affective socialization: TW more perseverance for future achievement. TW mothers talk much less about their children’s pride and their own pride in response to their children’s achievement. Instead, they tend to socialize their children in an outlook toward the future with more perseverance. The following segment between a mother and her nine-year-old son Yun exemplifies this tendency.

TW Example (22):

-
1. M: Mom was very moved that time.
2. C: Mm-hmm.

3. M: Knowing that you weren't willing to give up, fighting to the very end in the chess competition, persisting, persisting, did you ...?
4. C: Mm-hmm.
5. M: Wow, you turned from losing to winning, was it not true? That's why ... mom was very relieved that time. So mom really hopes that you will use the same normal speed in your future chess play. But not willing to give up, not accept losing so quickly, and giving your 100% can be applied to doing anything.
6. C: Giving my 100% to anything I do.
7. M: Oh, yes, that's great.

The mother helps Yun recall his dramatic achievement in one chess competition where Yun was losing at first, but did not give up and instead persisted with the same effort. He ended up winning. His mother was very moved by her son's virtue (T1 and T3). But she does not express pride, although surely a sense of relief (T5). In the same turn, she offers a general principle of applying all of these good virtues to anything that Yun does. Without any quibble, Yun recites this principle (T6), which meets his mother's full approbation in the end (T7).

I attempted to show twenty-two examples of MCC, half from each culture. It is, however, important to point out that this set of discourse analysis barely scratches the surface of the very rich data we collected. Earlier in the chapter, I acknowledged that there are many more topics, layers, and perspectives that discourse analysis can enlighten. Nonetheless, the current set of analyses yields important insight into the role culture may play in parental socialization of children's learning beliefs. The unique contribution of discourse analysis is displaying an otherwise enigmatic process of child development in real time but in slow motion.

PREVALENT AND EFFECTIVE SOCRATIC AND CONFUCIAN TUTORS AT HOME

Both sequential and discourse analysis suggest that there are ample Socratic tutors in the EA homes and ample Confucian tutors in Chinese-heritage homes. Although we only collected mother-child conversations, there is no reason to believe that EA fathers would be any different. Given that many Confucian heritage families have grandparents and even other relatives living together, there is also no reason to believe that Chinese extended kin would be any different either. In fact, our research⁴⁰ on immigrant Chinese adolescents' homes shows that this Confucian tutoring style is offered not

only by the parents, but also grandparents and other relatives even when they reside on different continents. For low-income families, when parents are not able to offer such help, the more capable of the extended kin step in.

Taken together, EA socialization in learning centers on the core beliefs about the child's mind and positive affect. Particularly emphasized are the distinct qualities of the self with two sides. First is the child's mind with heightened attention to how his or her mind works and how the child is to use it to explore the world, to gain understanding, and to achieve ingenuity, creativity, and productivity. Second, the child's intrinsic motivation such as interest, curiosity, excitement, fun, and enjoyment in the learning process is of utmost importance. The affect for achievement is pride in oneself. The task of molding their children into honoring these beliefs and behaving and feeling accordingly is carried out by parents, which is crucial during the preschool and early elementary school age. Our data show that mothers are highly skillful tutors. The best model of Western mind socialization is the age-honored Socratic tutoring style that is still widely admired and promoted in today's Western education. Comparing the two, the way mothers engage the less-than-fully qualified members of the culture – their children – is not very different from the master Socrates himself when he demonstrated his tutoring of the slave boy in geometry and succeeded in opening a nascent but capable mind. Unsurprisingly, the Socratic tutoring style finds tireless and effective replication in the EA homes. Such socialization aims at helping the child discover the greatness of the self as a learner.

Socialization of Confucian learning values also takes the form of parental tutoring of children at home. Like their EA counterparts, mothers are equally adept at carrying out this task. The difference lies in *what* they tutor their children about and *how* they go about doing that. The core beliefs are the Confucian learning virtues that are held to have causal power for the learning process and outcomes. The tutoring style also resembles the Confucian way of talking; the mother's guiding authority is assumed by herself and her child; not guiding their children in learning is a parental moral failure in Chinese culture. She attributes good learning to application of good virtues and poor learning to lack thereof. Positive and negative affects are also pivot around the learning virtues. Attributing learning to virtues clarifies for the child what is inherently in the child: capacity to be virtuous, and therefore the inherent, inexhaustible ability to learn well. But the realization of such morally endowed potential requires continuous effort on the part of the child. For this reason, mothers are compelled to instruct more rather than to leave learning to be a matter of children's choice, driven by their interest and fun. Also for this reason, maternal focus is always on the

child's continuous betterment in learning rather than on securing pride and self-greatness in the child, regardless of good or poor outcomes.

NOTES

1. See note 11 to Chapter 4.
2. See note 6 to Chapter 3.
3. See note 15 to Chapter 1; Chamberlain, P., & Patterson, G. R. (1995). Discipline and child compliance in parenting. In M. Bornstein (Ed.), *Handbook of parenting, Vol. 4* (pp. 205–225). Hillsdale, NJ: Erlbaum; Edwards, C. P. (1989). The transition from infancy to early childhood: A difficult transition and a difficult theory. In V. R. Briker & G. H. Gossen (Eds.), *Ethnographic encounters in Southern Mesoamerica: Essays in honor of Evon Z. Vogt, Jr.* (pp. 167–175). Austin: University of Texas Press; and Eisenberg, N., Cumberland, A., & Spinrad, T. L. (1998). Maternal socialization of emotion. *Psychological Inquiry*, 9, 241–273 for general reading on this topic.
4. Shweder, R. A. (2011). Commentary: Ontogenetic cultural psychology. In L. A. Jensen (Ed.), *Bridging cultural and developmental psychology: New syntheses in theory, research and policy* (pp. 303–310). New York: Oxford University Press.
5. See note 3 to this chapter.
6. Fivush, R., & Nelson, K. (2006). Parent–child reminiscing locates the self in the past. *British Journal of Developmental Psychology*, 24(1), 235–251; and Van Abbema, D. L., & Bauer, P. J. (2008). Autobiographical memory in middle childhood: Recollections of the recent and distant past. *Memory*, 13(8), 829–845.
7. Miller, P. J., Sandel, T. L., Liang, C.-H., & Fung, H. (2001). Narrating transgressions in Longwood: The discourses, meanings, and paradoxes of an American socializing practice. *Ethos*, 29(2), 159–186; Wang, Q. (2001). “Did you have fun?” American and Chinese mother–child conversations about shared emotional experiences. *Cognitive Development*, 16, 693–715; and see the first reference in note 25 to Chapter 4. Researchers also collect observational data and videotape mother–child interactions, also a real-time socialization process.
8. See note 63 to Chapter 4; and Li, J., Fung, H., Liang, C.-H., Resch, J., & Luo, L. (2008, July). Guiding for self-discovery or self-betterment: European American and Taiwanese mothers talking to their children about learning. In A. Bernardo (Chair), *Achievement motivation and achievement attribution among Asian students: Insights from qualitative data*. Invited paper symposium by the International Congress of Psychology, Berlin, Germany.
9. Atkinson, J. M., & Heritage, J. (Eds.). (1984). *Structures of social action: Studies in the conversation analysis*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
10. See note 8 to this chapter.
11. Bakeman, R., & Gottman, J. M. (1986). *Observing interaction: An introduction to sequential analysis*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press; and Bakeman, R., & Quera, V. (1995). *Analyzing interaction: Sequential analysis with SDIS and GSEQ*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
12. See note 11 to this chapter for technical details.
13. See note 11 to this chapter.

14. See the second reference in note 8 to this chapter and the first reference in note 61 to Chapter 3 for technical details of how we quantified our qualitative data in general. For the current sequential analysis, we first took a random 20% of our MCCs (about forty-two) in order to code our data. Two coders from each culture, unaware of our hypotheses, looked at the MCCs from their respective culture. A list of possible codes was generated by each coding group. Then the two teams met to integrate their codes into a single list. These procedures led to the establishment of fifty-nine sets of codes, one for mothers and one for children, given that each MCC followed the mother→child→mother→child sequence.
15. See the second reference in note 8 to this chapter and the first reference in note 61 to Chapter 3 for achieving reliability in such coding as a convention in the field. Two steps were taken for coding: (1) reliability coding, where two coders from each culture, unaware of the study's hypotheses, followed a procedure to code another random sample of 20% of our data. Their task was to apply independently the fifty-nine sets of codes accurately and reliably to code the data. After coding a few MCCs, they discussed their agreements and disagreements and continued their coding/discussion until they completed the whole 20%. While keeping track of agreements, the coders also listed two kinds of disagreements: (1) an event noted by one coder as present but by another as absent and (2) an event noted by one coder as belonging to one code but by another coder as belonging to another code. The second step was for either coder of each cultural team to use the fifty-nine sets of codes to code their respective MCCs after reliability was achieved.
16. See the first reference in note 11 to this chapter. Both disagreements and agreements were computed for Cohen's *kappa*, an index for reliability coding. For European-American MCCs, Cohen's *kappas* were .83 for good and .91 for poor learning, and Taiwanese MCCs, Cohen's *kappas* were .85 for good and .94 for poor learning. These were excellent according to established conventions in the field.
17. Because our data came from only 209 mother-child pairs, we needed to reduce our codes in order to accommodate the amount of data we collected. Thus, we collapsed the coded data based on our fifty-nine sets of codes into eight sets. This regrouping of coded data necessarily moved the conceptually more concrete themes/topics to more abstract ones.
18. All odds ratios were computed at 95% confidence interval, and all presented differences were significant at $p < .05$. I am tremendously grateful to Roger Bakeman for his step-by-step guidance on sequential analysis we conducted here. I am also grateful to Wanchun Wei who helped code the Taiwanese data with another coder and subsequently ran these analyses with different versions of Bakeman's GSEQ software.
19. As an advantage of sequential analysis, any time the mother starts is tallied for four turns, and the same applies to the child as a starter. Of course, each MCC began with the mother as the lead as structured by our interview. However, as the MCC unfolded, the two took turns to converse. Therefore, either the mother or the child could lead a given sequence. Because MCC was done with the two topics of good-versus-poor learning, I present two graphs that juxtapose EA and TW on good and two on poor learning.

20. Schiffrin, D. (1994). *Approaches to discourse: Language as social interaction*. Malden, MA: Blackwell; and Gumperz, J. J., Drew, P., Goodwin, M. H., & Schiffrin, D. (1982). *Discourse strategies*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
21. See the section titled “Western Classroom Discourse and Socialization” in Chapter 8 for several examples of discourse analysis in both European-American and Chinese-heritage language classrooms, which shed important light on the effects of teacher talk on students’ learning and self-understanding.
22. See notes 9 and 20 to this chapter.
23. To be sure, in order to do full justice to our data, we are continuing our analysis beyond this initial step and awaiting different insights from this ongoing endeavor.
24. Vygotsky, L. S. (1978). *Mind in society: The development of higher psychological processes*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; Cole, M. (1998). *Cultural Psychology: A once and future discipline*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; Bruner, J. (1987). *Actual minds, possible worlds*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; Rogoff, B. (1990). *Apprenticeship in thinking: Cognitive development in social context*. New York: Oxford University Press; and Wertsch, J. V. (1996). A sociocultural approach to socially shared cognition. In P. Baltes & U. Staudinger (Eds.), *Interactive minds* (pp. 85–100). New York: Cambridge University Press.
25. See Gottfried, A. E., Fleming, J. S., & Gottfried, A. W. (1998). Role of cognitive stimulating home environment in children’s academic intrinsic motivation: A longitudinal study. *Child Development*, 69, 1448–1460; and Bradly, R. H., & Corwyn, R. F. (2005). Caring for children around the world: A view from HOME. *International Journal of Behavioral Development*, 29(6), 468–478 for examples.
26. All names are pseudonyms.
27. The first column of numbers indicates turns taken by the mother and her child.
28. T1, T2, and so forth are abbreviations of turns corresponding to the numbering in note 26 to this chapter.
29. Jin Li translated all Taiwanese MCCs.
30. Baumrind, D. (1980). New directions in socialization research. *American Psychologist*, 35, 639–652.
31. See Steinberg, L., Dornbusch, S., & Brown, B. (1992). Ethnic differences in adolescent achievement: An ecological perspective. *American Psychologist*, 47, 723–729; and Eaton, M. J., & Dembo, M. H. (1997). Differences in the motivational beliefs for Asian-American and Non-Asian students. *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 89(3), 433–440 for examples of such characterization.
32. See the fourth reference in note 24 to this chapter; and Moll, L. C. (1995). *Vygotsky and education: Instructional implications and applications of sociohistorical psychology*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
33. See note 5 to Chapter 5.
34. See Tsai, J. L., Louie, J. Y., Chen, E. E., & Uchida, Y. (2007). Learning what feelings to desire: Socialization of ideal affect through children’s storybooks.

- Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 33(1), 17–30 for research on how we feel originating from how our cultures socialize us to feel.
35. Gergen, K. J. (2010). The acculturated brain. *Theory & Psychology*, 20(6), 795–816.
 36. Harkness, S., & Super, C. M. (Eds.) (1996). *Parents' cultural belief systems: Their origins, expressions, and consequences*. New York: Guilford.
 37. Gottman, J. M., Katz, L. F., & Hooven, C. (1996). Parental meta-emotion philosophy and the emotional life of families: Theoretical models and preliminary data. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 10(3), 243–268; and Gottman, J. M. (1996). *The heart of parenting: How to raise an emotionally intelligent child*. New York: Simon & Shuster.
 38. Eisenberg, N., Spinrad, T. L., & Cumberland, A. (1998). The socialization of emotion: Reply to commentaries. *Psychological Inquiry*, 9(4), 317–333, p. 317.
 39. See the first reference in note 37 to this chapter; Ramsden, S. R., & Hubbard, J. A. (2002). Family expressiveness and parental emotion coaching: Their role in children's emotion regulation and aggression. *Journal of Abnormal Child Psychology*, 30(6), 657–667; Spinrad, T. L., Eisenberg, N., Gaertner, B., Popp, T., Smith, C. L., Kupfer, A. et al. (2007). Relations of maternal socialization and toddlers' effortful control to children's adjustment and social competence. *Developmental Psychology*, 43(5), 1170–1186; and Brophy-Herb, H. E., Schiffman, R. F., Bocknek, E. L., Dupuis, S. B., Fitzgerald, H. E. et al. (2011). Toddlers' social-emotional competence in the contexts of maternal emotion socialization and contingent responsiveness in a low-income sample. *Social Development*, 20(1), 73–92 for such research findings.
 40. See the second reference in note 4 to Chapter 3.